

SIXTY YEARS A BOOKMAN

*WITH OTHER
RECOLLECTIONS AND REFLECTIONS*

BY
JOSEPH SHAYLOR

LONDON
SELWYN & BLOUNT, LTD.
21 YORK BUILDINGS, ADELPHI, W.C.

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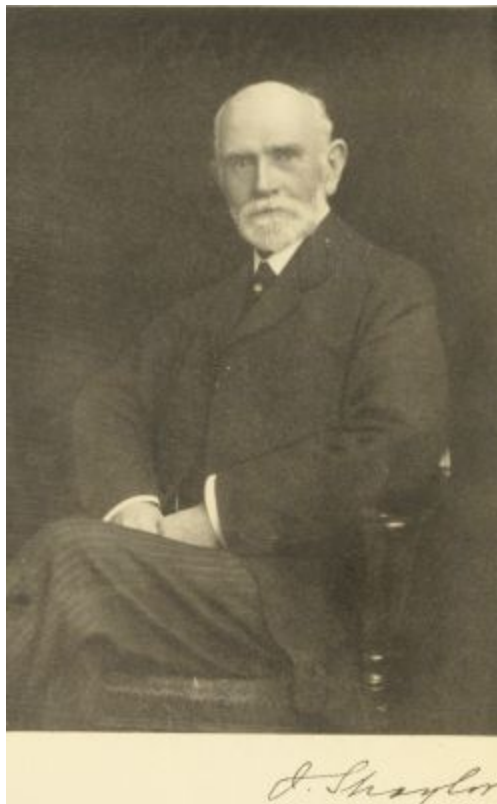
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BOOKMAN, WITH OTHER RECOLLECTIONS AND REFLECTIONS

SIXTY YEARS A BOOKMAN

WITH OTHER RECOLLECTIONS AND REFLECTIONS

BY THE SAME AUTHOR

THE FASCINATION OF BOOKS AND OTHER ESSAYS
THE PLEASURES OF BOOKLAND
IN FRIENDSHIP'S GARDEN
LIBERTY AND BROTHERHOOD, ETC., ETC.



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21 YORK BUILDINGS, ADELPHI, W.C.

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TO
MY CHILDREN
AND ALSO TO
MY MANY FRIENDS IN
THE BOOK-SELLING TRADE
WITH THE SINCERE WISH THAT THEIR LIVES
MAY BE CROWNED WITH AS MUCH SUCCESS
AND HAPPINESS AS THAT WHICH
HAS BLESSED MY CAREER

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PREFACE

AT the request of numerous friends, but with some hesitation, I have decided to issue a short account of certain of my experiences and impressions during a long and delightful association with the bookselling trade. In doing so, I hope that it may find a welcome with those members of the trade with whom I have been in happy association for over sixty years, and that my experience may be a stimulus to those who are still plodding their way among the many details of what I consider one of the most interesting and fascinating trades, a trade of which all the details are never learned.

The bookselling trade has its pleasurable associations as well as its drawbacks, and, although my early experiences had not great attractions for me, yet, owing to industry and attention to business, I have much pleasure in looking back upon what from many points of view may be considered as a prosperous career.

Personally, I love the making and selling of books, and sincerely hope that these callings may still have a future far and away greater than the period through which I have passed.

In addition to "Recollections" of a personal character, I have included portions of a few articles which I think may interest my readers and friends. These have appeared at various times, and I hope that they will now meet with as kindly a reception as they did when they were first published.

"Sixty Years a Bookman" is intended for three classes of readers—my Personal Friends, the Bookselling Trade, and the General Public; and I trust that there will be found something in these records of a long and busy life to appeal to them all.

JOSEPH SHAYLOR

GLOUCESTER HOUSE, HOLDEN ROAD,
Woodside Park, N.

CHAPTER I

My Early Life in the Country

IN what is known as the Stroud Valley, Gloucestershire, or, as it was deservedly called by Queen Victoria, the Golden Valley, stands a little straggling village called the Thrupp, in which on July 12, 1844, I was born; but my early recollections of this beautiful valley began at a village about one mile distant, named Swells Hill, to which my parents afterwards removed. This village is situated on the side of the eastern portion of the Cotswolds, a district full of beautiful hills, gorge-like valleys, dells and glades, celebrated not only for its beauty and historical associations but for

its numerous industries. Swells Hill overlooks the busy village of Brimscombe and is on the fringe of the delightful Minchinhampton Common, which consists of some thousand acres of open country; its highest part being about 650 feet above the sea level; on it, there are many local traditions of great battles having been fought, and on one particular spot in the centre of the Common the celebrated George Whitfield preached in 1743 to thousands of people.

Minchinhampton Common was presented to the parish so named in the reign of Henry VIII by Dame Alice Hampton. On it are now golf links, which are well known all over the country and many notable contests have been played there by some of our most celebrated professionals. From the quarries on this Common I have often collected fossils of snakes and other reptiles which I suppose belonged to some prehistoric period, but how long ago I have been unable to learn. Pit dwellings, long and round tunnels with camps and earthworks, abound in this district. Some of the depressions in the surface of the Common vary in depth. I used to be told that they were the burying places of those who had fought in the days of the Civil Wars. I cannot of course guarantee the correctness of this statement, but I do know that these depressions have frequently given me in my school days very much pleasure, as in the winter they were often filled with snow, and a good run and jump landed one in the centre of the hollow. It was a great pleasure to see who could jump the farthest and come out the wettest.

As far as I can remember, most of my early education, or what may be called my twopenny education, was acquired at an old-fashioned Dame's School and a local Church School where the main ideas of education were answering the questions in Pinnock's "Catechism" and learning, and I must say immediately forgetting, the questions and answers from the Church Catechism; but I have no doubt I received impressions which were useful in after life.

When about nine years of age, I was sent to Amberley School. To reach this School I had to cross Minchinhampton Common, nearly two miles from my home; this distance I traversed sometimes four times a day. At that time home lessons were considered of great importance, but the weariness of them made a lasting impression upon me. However, it was at this School that I obtained the best part of my education.

With Amberley I have many associations never to be forgotten. I remember how when nearing the School I listened for the Master's whistle which he always appeared in the open to blow, and how considerate he was with the boys who came from a distance before marking them late. How on occasions when the hounds on a wintry day came at full speed past our School leave was given to some of us boys to chase with them. Many a good run I have had following them over hedges and ditches until outdistanced, but the excitement left behind very pleasant recollections, and was the cause of my writing the following verses:

Hurrah for To-morrow! 'Tis the first hunting day,
And with the good hounds we'll hark hark away,
For the Fox will be drawn from the thick bushy wood,
It's the rascal that stole the grey duck's little brood.

You remember the time, 'twas one bright summer morn,
When the hens had their chicks and the bees had a swarm,
And the duck had her ducklings, and fine ones were they,
As e'er swam on a pond, or play'd pranks in the hay.

Farmer Giles was out early, the sheep had gone wrong,
And old Towler was with him, they scarcely had gone
When that crafty old Reynard, who had watched them away,
Stole the ducks and he had them for dinner that day.

How he must have enjoyed each tender young bone
As he scrunched and he scrunched till each tit-bit was gone;
But who would begrudge him a feast in his den,
I dare wager a bet he won't do it again.

For we're off in the morn, while the true scent is strong,
To capture his brush and it won't take us long,
For the horses and hounds are all fit for the fray,
So Ahoy! Tally Ho! Tally Ho! Harkaway!

Close by the Schools stands Rose Cottage where Mrs. Craik, then Miss Muloch, wrote her most successful novel "John Halifax, Gentleman." This was published in 1857, the year I was at school, and I have no doubt I must

often have seen Miss Muloch when she was writing her great novel. The background of this story runs from Tewkesbury through Nailsworth to Amberley Common; the latter, figuring in the novel as Enderly Flats, is described as the highest tableland in England. The whole neighbourhood is identified with incidents delineated in the book, and in Amberley Churchyard the little blind daughter of John Halifax and Ursula lies at rest.

In the small village of Woodchester, in the valley below Amberley, there is an important Monastery which contains many interesting associations, but my recollections are more concerned with the parish church of Woodchester where I remember being taken by my mother to see what is left of some old Roman villa with tessellated pavement and other remains. I believe these are uncovered at certain times and the public allowed to inspect them.

One other of my youthful enjoyments was the occasional fishing and bathing in the Thames and Severn Canal. This canal joins together at Lechlade these two great rivers. In the canal as it passed through the Golden Valley, there was always a good supply of water and the fishing here was very good. I never got beyond roach, dace and perch, but there were frequently pike and other fish caught by the expert. Anyone who has indulged in fishing, if only as I did in my boyhood, will never forget the fascination it has upon the lover of sport, and I pity the boy who has not the sportive instinct. I learned to swim also in these waters, but want of opportunity in after years prevented my ever becoming a really good swimmer.

Looking back upon my boyhood from the standpoint of to-day, I am inclined to think that, practically, education does not begin until the first steps are taken in the business of life, although from my own experience the great influence exercised upon character by a good mother, which I fortunately had, lasts with a boy and helps to mould his life and disposition more than he can at the moment anticipate. I am quite sure that through the early start I made both in the country and in London, nothing contributed more to my even routine and carefully considered actions than the influence exercised upon me by a mother's love.

In September, 1857, I was sent on trial, before being apprenticed, to a Mr. Bucknell, a bookseller in George Street, Stroud, and, apparently proving satisfactory, was afterwards apprenticed for five years, "out of doors," that

is living at home, with the magnificent remuneration of one shilling per week for the first year, increasing by one shilling per week at the beginning of the next year, and to be continued upon the same ratio for five years.

Mr. Bucknell, however, after fifteen months of my apprenticeship sold the business to Mr. John Clark and I was what is called "turned over" to him, but the period of my apprenticeship was extended to seven years and a little more liberal salary given me. When Mr. Bucknell left, he presented me with a copy of Charles Mackay's poems in which he wrote the following after my name: "With an earnest wish that his future life may be deserving of that approval from his fellow-men which he now receives after fifteen months of his apprenticeship from S.G. Bucknell." Without being in any way conceited, I cannot help feeling that his good wishes have to a certain extent been fulfilled.

From a quiet village life to the busy town of Stroud was a great change. My time for work was from eight o'clock in the morning until eight at night six days of the week, summer and winter, and my only holidays were Good Friday and Christmas Day. The Bill originating Bank Holidays had not then been passed. Sometimes during the winter months the walk home was anything but pleasant, especially as I had to walk beside the canal for a considerable distance and more than once had a narrow escape from falling in. It is a truism that familiarity breeds contempt, and I must admit that this familiarity strengthened me in what to many would have been a dangerous journey, and it has no doubt helped me in keeping my nerves and my temper from running away with me. However, all's well that ends well, and although during my seven years' apprenticeship I had many temptations and dangers, yet I think I came through them stronger both in mind and body. I remember that occasionally on my morning walk through some of the lanes to business, I would meet that sportsman Mr. Paul Hawkins Fisher with his attendants, each carrying a hawk on his hand, well hooded; sometimes, I have seen them let fly when they would attack some startled bird, but I understood they were only training the hawks for future warfare. It was, however, sportive food for my imagination.

During my years of apprenticeship many events happened, both social and political, that interested me, and I can only write them down as my memory helps me and not in any way in the order of their happening. One of my earliest recollections was of an election before vote by ballot was

introduced. The members for the Borough were Edward Horsman and G. Poulet Scrope, the latter an author of considerable importance. I remember that, although there was no opposition to the members, speaking on the hustings, for the nomination, continued until twelve o'clock, with the intention of nominating Lord John Russell should he not have been successful in the constituency he was fighting; but he was successful, so no nomination was necessary. I had occasionally the pleasure of seeing Lord John Russell, as he lived near Amberley, from which his eldest son took the title of Viscount Amberley.

Speaking of contests but of another character, it was in 1860 the fight between Tom Sayers and J.C. Heenan took place. What a tremendous excitement it produced! I well remember the day after the fight, having fetched the newspapers from the London train and folded them in the shop, how I stopped every minute to read another line describing the fight and how angry my master was at my taking so long. But I could not help it, for the details were quite worth the trouble I brought upon myself. Some months later I had the pleasure of seeing Sayers box in connexion with a travelling circus. It was one of the red-letter days in my life to see the man of whom I had thought so much, showing his skill as a boxer. It was generally understood that it was at Stroud that Tom Sayers had his first fight; he was a bricklayer and was engaged in work at the Stroud Brewery, and falling out with one of his fellow-workmen, a fight followed which probably led to further developments. I have also seen his opponent J.C. Heenan boxing in a circus, but I did not consider him in any way an equal to Tom Sayers.

Although my time was fully occupied, I was able to enjoy a good game of cricket with some of my many friends on Rodborough Common. We used to meet at five o'clock in the morning, and, after a good game, had breakfast before starting work at eight o'clock. I also joined a class to learn Latin: there was a dear old gentleman bachelor who loved literature and education and he took in hand some half-dozen young fellows to teach them Latin. We used to meet at his house at eight in the evening for one hour's tuition. I enjoyed it and managed to master the early chapters of Virgil's "Æneid," and, though I am afraid the results have not been very great, the little knowledge I obtained has been useful. I was also much interested in a singing class, over which a Mr. Helmore, brother to the Rev. T. Helmore,

the great Church choirmaster, presided. We gave performances in the Subscription Rooms of "The Messiah," "The Creation" and other musical classics. I have often thought of the absurdity of one of the choirmaster's eccentricities when performing "The Creation." Very early in the oratorio the words are, "And God said let there be light, and there was light." Before the singing began the lights were turned down and I was placed near the man who turned on the gas. At the opportune moment I had to give the signal, the light was turned on and light became a fact. I have often thought how almost profane it was, but I believe it passed without any serious protest.

Another yearly event which became fixed in my mind was the appearance of Dr. Cumming to speak on the coming end of the world. There was a wealthy lady of Amberley who was a great believer in Dr. Cumming, and each year he came down and stayed with her and always delivered one of his unfulfilled prophecies. It was my duty to take the tickets and see the audience into their seats, but, as the audience year by year grew smaller by degrees and beautifully less, this was very easy work. Like most moderate-sized towns at this period, Stroud had its Young Men's Institute, of which I was a member, and it was the custom during the winter to have lectures, etc. I well remember the great success that always attended the lectures given by George Dawson, a preacher, lecturer and politician, and George Grossmith, the father of the well-known actor in Gilbert and Sullivan's plays. These lectures were usually of a literary or biographical character and undoubtedly laid the foundations for thought and study in the minds of those who listened to them.

During my apprenticeship, my master, Mr. John Clark, was sometimes very exacting, and I know I had to thank Mrs. Clark and some of their daughters for helping to an extent to ease my work, and for making my strenuous life run smoothly. Part of my work was to learn printing. This I did, and was able to set up the type of a volume of sermons by a local vicar. The volume made no reputation, either for the vicar or the producer of the work.

It was, however, in the buying and selling of books that I was most interested. These were the great days of the poets, who then had large sales, Tupper's "Proverbial Philosophy," I think the greatest. What a change from then to now! I have no doubt that if you asked for this book to-day in a bookseller's shop no one would know of its existence, but, without doubt,

those of Tupper and other poets were the principal books given as presents. I remember that Tennyson's "Enoch Arden," published by Edward Moxon in 1864, even in such a small town as Stroud had a large sale. I understand that 50,000 copies of this book were sold during the first year of its publication.

There is one thing I was greatly blessed with—a good memory; and I can safely say I knew every book in our stock. When a traveller came round for orders, I was always stationed near my master and the traveller and if an order was being given I had to say whether the book was in stock or not. Those were also the days when booksellers sold patent medicines, in which a large trade was done; especially with such articles as Holloway's, Morrison's, and other pills, with various preparations to cure every disease under the sun.

In looking back to those times, I have often dwelt upon the thought whether it is best for youths to be brought up under severe discipline or under easy surroundings and have come to the conclusion that the happy medium is most desirable, for in my own case and although my master Mr. Clark was a straightforward honourable man, he was not a man who sympathized with labour, but looked upon it as something one had to put up with; but where a man is just and honourable as he was this influence is for good, and labour is made more pleasant and agreeable. I have much to thank Mr. Clark for, especially in the directions mentioned, and always feel that the thoroughness of his business habits had a lasting effect upon me. I can look back upon my seven years' apprenticeship with much thankfulness, not only for my personal good health but the many pleasant associations with which I was surrounded.

CHAPTER II

My Early London Experiences

IN September, 1864, I came to London, although not for the first time, as I had made two visits to the metropolis before this important event in my life.

On one of these occasions I well remember sitting on an omnibus which came down from Snow Hill and at the bottom of the hill a horse was switched on to the front of the 'bus to pull it up Holborn Hill which was then paved with rugged stones. Even with three horses, they had to pull from one side to the other in their effort to reach the top. This dip is now bridged over by the Holborn Viaduct, which I remember seeing Queen Victoria declare open in 1872. The other occasion was to visit the Exhibition of 1862. It was a great revelation and interested me much.

Before coming to my situation in London, I had quite made up my mind that I would see anything there was to be seen that was within my reach and means. I think one of the earliest events which happened was the hanging at Newgate of Muller, who murdered a Mr. Briggs whilst riding in a train from Liverpool Street to Bow. He committed the murder and managed to escape to America, but was deported, tried and condemned to be hung. In those days the gallows was erected in the Old Bailey, the night before the execution, and the condemned was brought out through the prison door in the Old Bailey and mounted steps to the scaffold, with Calcraft the hangman walking beside him. In this way you obtained a good view of the culprit. I arrived at the Old Bailey at five in the morning so had a long wait until eight, the time of the execution, but the talking and byplay helped to pass the time. I had a good view of the terrible ordeal and came away with some new experiences, one of which was that I lost in the crowd a very dainty scarf pin which had been given to me on leaving Stroud. This taught me the advisability of leaving my valuables at home when going into crowds.

I had now settled down at Islington, which was just one mile from the General Post Office and when leaving home too near 8.30, which was the time for getting to business, I could take a cab with a friend for this distance. It cost us sixpence, threepence each for one mile; but cab fares, like many other things, have changed since then.

Before coming to London, I had never been inside a theatre. My first experience was at Sadlers Wells Theatre, where a Miss Marriott was playing "Hamlet." My interest and enthusiasm in that play has from that time never ceased. I went to see it on Monday, on Tuesday, and on Wednesday, and if funds had allowed my inclination would have continued for the rest of the week. "Hamlet" made a greater impression on me than

any sermon I ever heard. I learned a great deal of the play by heart, and, although I have seen "Hamlet" played many times since, it never impressed me so much as it did on that occasion at Sadlers Wells. This theatre was opened in 1844 and for some twenty years Samuel Phelps was associated with it, his aim being to produce all Shakespeare's plays, but he only succeeded in producing thirty-four of them. Phelps was a great tragedian, and I have often seen him acting at Drury Lane Theatre. From very early in my youth I have been a lover of Shakespeare, and this was mainly brought about through one of my sisters joining with me in taking Cassell's edition in seven-penny monthly numbers, which we both read as they were issued. They were published in three volumes and I have the copy now bound in calf. Like many others of my books, they have to me a speaking remembrance.

It was in 1867 that a new and interesting experience came my way. For many years various associations had held meetings in Hyde Park to air their grievances, either imaginary or otherwise. At one of these, the Home Secretary, Spencer H. Walpole, decided that a different method should be adopted in their management. This was objected to by a particular Association and they defied the Home Secretary, with the result that he had the gates of the Park closed against them. The people were so incensed at this that although the railings of the Park were as far as possible protected by the police, the crowds were too strong for them and broke the railings in many places and held their meeting. I was among those who helped to pull down the railings and got for my trouble a good blow on my back from a policeman's truncheon. However, I had an experience which was new and interesting: I cannot say who was in the right, but I remember the Home Secretary had to resign a few days afterwards for what was stated to be lack of tactfulness in regard to this meeting.

One of the most sickening and disgusting sights which I remember was the old slaughter-houses of Smithfield. This Market stood where Paternoster Square now stands. Cattle were driven into the market during the night, bullocks and sheep, and were killed in the early morning and sometimes during the day. I have watched them being slaughtered and seen the blood flow from the slaughter-houses into Paternoster Row. To people of to-day it does not seem possible that such a thing could be allowed in the heart of the City of London. The butchers would often parade round their shops with

what was called a Cleaver Chorus; this was done by bringing together with a clash a marrow-bone and their cleaver or hatchet, and quite an attractive sound was produced but not much harmony. When there was an execution taking place at Newgate, these men would gather together in a body in their disgusting blood-soaked overalls and just before the time for the execution rush singing into the crowd surrounding the gallows. However thick the crowd was, the people would give way rather than come into contact with these greasy and disgusting butchers, who by these means got a front position in what should have been a sad and mournful ceremony.

It was probably through there being so much more meat near at hand that the prices for lunch were much cheaper then than they are now. I remember in Warwick Lane there used to be a popular refreshment house called "The Bedford," and many times I have had a good lunch there for sixpence, a lunch which consisted of toad-in-the-hole (it was made of a good beef-steak in the middle of batter pudding) for fourpence, potatoes one penny, and ale one penny. Things have changed greatly since those times. There also used to be in the Oxford Arms passage, situated where some of the St. Paul's residentiary houses now stand, an inn, in association with the hay market held there, named the Oxford Arms. Here each day there was brought on to the table a good joint of beef or a leg of mutton from which you could cut and come again, with vegetables, pastry, etc., all for the price of one shilling. For the sake of many in the City, one is often tempted to wish some of these old customs were with us still.

I have a lingering remembrance of an important event occurring just before bedtime in December, 1867. A fire was evident somewhere at the West End, so off I started and was in time to see the last of Her Majesty's Theatre which was that night entirely burned down. It was a grand sight, but the crowd which collected was unbearable. I understood that at the time an opera was being played and several of the great performers of the day, such as Titiens, Christine Neilson, and Santley, were among the artistes present. It was a sight never to be forgotten.

It was about this time that Adah Isaacs Menken, an American actress and poet and also the wife of J.C. Heenan, the prize fighter, was playing the hero in "Mazeppa" at Astley's Theatre. She was a splendid and attractive figure, and when she came on the stage, dressed only in tights, mounting her horse and riding away into the wilds to be picked to pieces by the birds,

she had a tremendous ovation. The performance was a great attraction and most young men made a point of seeing it. It was said that a bet had been made as to whether the actress's legs were padded and the attendant who helped her on to the horse was bribed to pinch her leg to settle the bet. I heard that he did so, and got a kick in return which not only settled the bet but also the attendant.

The changes that have been made in London since my early days have been very great. I never pass down Holborn but I think of the passage called Middle Row, which I have often gone through, in front of the delightful old-fashioned Shakespearean houses of which we are all so proud. At that time there was a row of houses on the other side of the passage, and at nearly the bottom of the hill stood the publishing house of Darton & Harvey. This, like many others, has been swept away by the present Holborn Viaduct. The Thames Embankment was opened within my early recollection, also the Law Courts; and there was also the sweeping away of Holywell Street, where I have passed many a pleasant hour poring over the boxes of old books in search of a treasure. I remember once, as I thought, buying for 2s. 6d. a book with not a very chaste reputation. It was done up very carefully in a sealed envelope and when I opened it at home I found it was an old soiled Common Prayer Book. I did not get what I expected, but perhaps it was better for me that I was swindled. London, however, is being made a city of which we are all proud. Although there is still much to be done, the changes and improvements have been great since my early days.

Going back to the Theatre and Music Hall, these were the times of the songs "Champagne Charlie is my name," sung by Leybourne, "The Bells go a Ringing for Sarah," by Kate Santley, Stead's "The Perfect Cure," and, from a different point of view, the delightful singing by Sims Reeves of "Come into the Garden, Maud," and Carlotta Patti of "Home, Sweet Home," and "Comin' through the Rye." These now appear very old-fashioned, but they touched the imagination more than many of the songs of the present day. Blondin was at this time at the height of his popularity. His performances at the Crystal Palace, and afterwards at the Alexandra Palace and other places, attracted great crowds. It made you hold your breath to watch him on the high rope balancing a four-legged chair and then stand upon it, or sometimes carry a man on his back across the rope or wheel him in a barrow.

Among other exhibitions, I remember seeing General Tom Thumb and Minnie Warren with their troop of midget humanity, performing at St. James's Hall. Cremorne Gardens and Highbury Barn were at this time at the height of their popularity, and although from where I lived it meant a night out to visit the former, the latter was within walking distance. I wanted to see everything possible, and I think so far I succeeded, for my wanderings were varied from the top of St. Paul's Cathedral and the Monument to the Cider Cellars in the Strand and to Nicholson's Judge and Jury and the Poesie Plastics of Leicester Square.

Living as I did at this time in the north of London, I frequently walked through Highbury to what is now the beautiful Finsbury Park. The New River was then an open stream beside which it was pleasant to walk. On passing through a wicket-gate, one came to a building called the Sluice House, at which refreshments could be procured. A path through a field took us to Finsbury Park Tavern on the site of which the refreshment houses in Finsbury Park now stand. Boats were let out for hire on the lake, and pigeon shooting was one of the sports carried on in the grounds. Many times have I seen a considerable number of these injured innocents brought down. This sport, I am pleased to think, is not so popular now as it was at that period.

It was, I suppose, somewhat natural to a young man who has been brought up in a very puritanical atmosphere and among the strictest sect of the Pharisees, to take every advantage of the liberty I was now enjoying. I was anxious, however, to see and hear some of the preachers of whom I had heard so much. This attraction, however, soon died away, because to an extent I found no sympathy. The first great preacher I went to hear was the Rev. C.H. Spurgeon. Unfortunately my impression of him was a bad one, for he had just given out his text when several people walked into the chapel. The preacher stopped and looked hard at the people entering. When they were seated, he said, "We are sorry we could not wait for you, but you will be in time to go away with the rest." I thought this a most unkind and uncalled-for remark, and made up my mind I would never hear him again, and I did not. Another incident, I suppose I must call it, or eccentricity, occurred at the only time I heard Dr. Parker at the City Temple. Before beginning his sermon he waited a few minutes and then said, "We are not

feeling quite well this evening, so shall dispense with our usual action." To me, this was nothing but unnecessary egotism.

The one man to whom I always enjoyed listening was the Rev. J.C.M. Bellew, who preached in Bloomsbury. He was a great elocutionist, his sermons were well constructed and interesting, and to me the music was the greatest charm of all. The most eloquent and informing sermon I ever heard was one by Canon Liddon, in St. Paul's Cathedral, on Buddha. He preached for one hour and a quarter, and never did I experience quicker or more intellectual enjoyment than on that occasion. I also had the pleasure of hearing, at Islington, Professor Huxley deliver one of his controversial addresses. Huxley's life was principally spent in the promulgating of right and truth, and his eloquence was almost an inspiration. The only time I had the pleasure of hearing John Bright speak was at the Highbury Congregational Church, when he presided at a lecture given by the Rev. R.W. Dale. A more eloquent introduction than that given by John Bright I have never heard.

Sport was always one of my fascinations, whether it was running, walking, boxing, or cricket. I have no doubt the cricket I so much enjoyed during my apprenticeship helped me in obtaining a position in the eleven at Stationers' Hall Court, where for many years a good team was always available for a Saturday afternoon game; and I am pleased to record that in these early days there were few things I looked forward to with greater pleasure than the Saturday afternoon cricket, especially when I was chosen as one of the eleven.

One Saturday afternoon an extraordinary incident took place at a cricket match, at which I was a spectator; it was between Middlesex and Nottingham, on the ground now held by the Smithfield Market near Holloway. Tom Hearn, the great Middlesex bowler, was holding the ball ready for delivery, when a pigeon came flying over the wicket. Hearn looked up and in a moment threw the ball into the air and struck the pigeon in the breast. The poor bird fluttered down close to the wicket. It was a clever shot and Hearn was greatly cheered.

Occasionally during the week, boxing was one of my great delights, and I flatter myself I was quite up to the average in this most useful exercise. I have seen most of the champion boxers of that period engaged in the noble

art of self-defence, and on one occasion I was persuaded to have the gloves on with a professional prize fighter, but my weak points were soon found out, and I felt it was best to leave well alone.

What greatly interested me on one occasion was my visit to a ratting match. The wager was laid on a terrier for £25 that he would kill 300 rats in fifteen minutes. The rats were taken out of traps and counted into a square pit, and as they fell in they rushed to one corner of it. When the 300 were all in, it was a wonderful sight to see them in a heap in one corner of the pit. The dog, Peter was his name, was put in the middle of the pit and when the referee called time, he was let go and the killing began with a vengeance. The bet was won with a minute to spare, and I can safely say I never spent fourteen minutes amid greater tension and excitement.

In these times, on Good Friday, there was always wrestling at the Agricultural Hall. I usually went and well remember the splendid contest between the Cornish and Cumberland wrestlers. It was great sport, and for a few minutes during the surging back and forward before a firm grip had been obtained by one of the giants, the spectators almost held their breath in the excitement. I often wonder whether this particular sport of wrestling has, like many other things, become almost a thing of the past, or is it that our lives have so changed that we now take little notice of such matters.

Although somewhat indirectly connected with sport, I have always derived a great deal of fun and enjoyment from watching the return of the visitors of the Epsom Races to see the Derby run. From Clapham Common to the Elephant and Castle, and on to the City there was for many hours one continuous stream of people and conveyances, some in good style, while others rode in donkey carts or any conveyance obtainable. These race-goers mostly sang comic songs, were all bent upon enjoyment, and in many cases the race appeared to be a secondary consideration. These enjoyments have now mostly passed away, a better tone prevails with the people, and the means of conveyance to Epsom Downs have been greatly accelerated. I once had the pleasure of seeing the Derby ran; it was in 1896, when the race was won by Persimmon, King Edward VII's (then Prince of Wales) horse. It was a splendid race, and never could there have been a greater reception than was given when the Prince came from the Stand after the race to lead his horse back to the weighing machine.

My experience on that occasion must have been almost a record. I left business at one o'clock, went by cab to London Bridge, caught a train to Epsom, arrived at my arranged stand on the race-course, and saw each race run until the Derby was over and the Prince had led his horse off the course; then to the station and back to town and was in business again at four o'clock—in all, three hours. This was a good record.

During the summer, with a small band of fellow-assistants, I often arranged pedestrian outings. We frequently started early on Saturday, after business, slept the night out and returned by train on Sunday evening. Two of these outings are still fresh in my memory. On the first occasion, we went by train to Gravesend, then walked to Chatham, where we spent a very uncomfortable night, thence to Rochester Cathedral and the Dickens country, afterwards walking to St. Mary's Cray and staying on the way to inspect Kit's Coty House in Kent, a prehistoric structure which belongs to the Stone or Bronze Age. It consists of a large flat stone supported by two other stones and is a link with the past and well worth a visit. From St. Mary's Cray we reached home by train.

Another of our outings was by rail to Hampton Court, then a walk to Staines, where we had to sleep on the floor and on billiard tables, but, not being very comfortable, we got up at three o'clock in the morning and spent our time, until breakfast was ready, rowing on the Thames. From Staines we walked to Windsor, and were in time for service at St. George's Chapel, and I had the pleasure of hearing the then Archbishop of Canterbury, Dr. Tait; thence home by train. Such outings as these can only be enjoyed at one period of life, and I have always been glad I undertook them when I did, for other things came into my life which made me, I hope, a better and happier man.

CHAPTER III

Some Recollections of Stationers' Hall Court

ALTHOUGH I have referred in another chapter to my early association with bookselling, yet it was not until my entry into the employ of Simpkin, Marshall & Co., on September 23, 1864, that my real bookselling experience commenced. This may not be quite in accord with the title I have chosen of "Sixty Years a Bookman," but, as previously stated, I served seven years' apprenticeship to a bookseller before entering the firm of Simpkin, Marshall & Co., and these two periods extend beyond that implied by the title of this book.

As long as my memory lasts, I shall never forget the first few weeks of my experience in this firm, from 8.30 in the morning until the work was finished. Up and down stairs and ladders searching for books made one so tired that sometimes I could scarcely crawl to my home. Even to this I soon became accustomed, and the tiredness to an extent, so far as my body was concerned, became a thing of the past; but it will never be effaced from my memory.

These were also the times when the principal day of the month was Magazine day, and after the ordinary business hours were over every one stopped to put together each customer's magazines. I quite think that if there were not then a greater number of different magazines published, they had, certainly as far as this firm was concerned, a much larger sale. Anyway, it was a day that one felt thankful to see finished. At this period late hours were considered inevitable, for during the winter season it was frequently ten o'clock before we got away, while some assistants in the firm and in other book firms at certain times worked until after twelve o'clock at night. I remember, when speaking of this to a fellow-assistant, being told that this was nothing to what it had been formerly: a short Saturday afternoon and no Bank Holiday, and occasionally some of the people would only see their homes three times during the week; they had to sleep on or under the counters. Fortunately, all these absurd arrangements are now ancient history and never again likely to be a part of what is called civilization or business methods.

I well remember my first holiday, if it can be so called. It was the Christmas following the September of my entering Simpkins. I wanted to spend it at Weston-super-Mare, and as Christmas came on Sunday, Monday was given as a holiday. I caught a G.W.R. train about ten o'clock on the Saturday evening. There was only a single line then to Weston, from a junction on the

main line at which we stopped. From here, in a single railroad carriage with a white horse attached to it, we jogged for many miles and arrived at our destination at six in the morning.

My friends were waiting for me, and we had a jolly Christmas. I started back by a midnight train on Monday, arriving in London at seven on the Tuesday morning. I had some breakfast and then went to business until nine o'clock at night. This was what was then called a Christmas holiday. But with all this, I can bear testimony to the kindness and consideration shown to the assistants by the partners of this period in the firm of Simpkin, Marshall & Co., especially Messrs. John, Frederick and William Miles; and as far as I am personally concerned, I shall always remember with a thankful heart the courtesy and consideration I received from them.

These were the times of Old Moore's and Hannay's Almanacs, the publishing day of the former being a great occasion. At this time it was published by the Stationers' Company, as nearly as possible on November 21, at twelve o'clock. On the day of publication the Hall doors were opened, and the porter who first got through with a sack-load of almanacs received a gift of, I think, five shillings. There were always a number of people to watch this publishing event, and the winner was greatly cheered.

At this time "Hannay's Almanac" also had a large sale, but it only survived a few years after the first issue of the greatly renowned "Whitaker's Almanack," now over fifty years old. This almanac deserves the success it has secured. No business or even private intelligence department can afford to be without it; it practically has no competitor, and the knowledge it contains might well be termed universal and encyclopædic.

While speaking of Stationers' Hall and Stationers' Court, I will try to remove an impression which suggests that the word Stationers originated from the locality in bygone times being connected with the paper trade. This is not so; but being so near St. Paul's Cathedral, it was one of the *stations* at which vendors of crosses and other wares for religious observances had their stands or shops for the sale of these articles; hence its origin. The following streets also derived their names through being near or associated with St. Paul's Cathedral: Paternoster Row, Creed Lane, Ave Maria Lane and Graces Court. In Ivy Lane dwelt the wax-chandlers who in bygone times supplied tapers for lighting the Cathedral.

I cannot say if religion at this period had a passion for more excitement than at the present time, but undoubtedly there were more books of that character sold than there are to-day. What immense sales such books as the following had: Hall's "Come to Jesus," "Heaven Our Home," "The Sinner's Friend," "Across the River," Beecher's "Life Thoughts," "The Pathway of Promise," "Able to Save," Baynes' "Lyra Anglicana," "Christ is Coming," "Letters from Hell," "The Gates Ajar," Oxenden's "Pathway of Safety," "The Heavenly Home," or the "Employment and Enjoyment of the Saints in Heaven," with works by Dr. Guthrie, Richard Weaver, Dr. Vaughan, A.K.H.B., Dr. Winslow, and books on the coming end of the world by Dr. Cummings. In fact, one of the leading journals of this time discussed the question as to what devotional books were most popular, and the answer given was, "Not the 'Imitation of Christ,'" but works telling the Christian how to make the best of both worlds, and describing heaven as minutely as if it were a first-class hotel, where every pleasure is provided for the elect. Judging from the titles this would appear correct, but fortunately this class of book has almost ceased to be, and works of a more reasonable and literary character have taken their place.

Some years ago I wrote an article bearing upon this subject, and as I feel that the words are as true to-day as when written, I here produce portions from the article which deals more fully with this question.

It must be apparent to anyone glancing through the publishers' lists of the books now being issued, and comparing them with the lists of fifty years ago, that a great decline has taken place in the production of religious books. This decline is observable not only in the old-fashioned religious publications which were looked upon as belonging to the classics, but also in the more modern productions of a like character. These latter sold by their thousands, but the demand for both appears at the present to have nearly passed away, and their sale is now of the most limited description.

In an attempt to account for this decline more or less plausible reasons have been adduced, but the most forcible, perhaps, is, that just now there is no religious wave passing over the country, nor are there any great ecclesiastics who have time or who consider it part of their duty to be continually issuing books on purely religious subjects. Add to this the fact that trade frequently runs in cycles, with the effect that the depression in this particular class of literature is just now at its lowest point. When this is so, something often

occurs to bring it back again to its normal condition, and this may prove to be the case in the production and sale of religious books.

A potent factor in this depression is undoubtedly the growth of independent thought, which was such a marked characteristic in the latter part of the nineteenth century. The influence of Puritanism, which so deeply affected English life, and which in past ages permeated the action and thought of this country, has now nearly spent itself, so the sale of old Puritan books has almost ceased. During that period the noblest characters were moulded from those appearing in the Bible; these are now shaped more by education and culture. Whether this will be to the advantage of the nation, must be left for a future generation to decide.

There is much truth in the remark that the literature of a nation largely indicates the disposition of its people; but this observation scarcely applies to the religious side of our national life, for, although there has been a great decline in the issue of religious books, the activity of nearly all sections of the Christian Church during the same period has been most marked. The result of this is the establishment by the various religious denominations of special publishing departments for their own particular class of religious works. They have also weekly and monthly periodicals which circulate amongst their own people and through their own channels; and although these with their books do not in all cases come through the ordinary distributing agencies, and are not always recorded in the return of books issued during the year, yet, even taking all this into account, there is undoubtedly a great decline in the issue of religious works.

For some years previous to this period many of our religious writers were at the height of their popularity and their books were having immense sales. Much of this success was due to the writers' influence in the pulpit. Among the most prominent was the Rev. J.R. Macduff, whose first and best known book, and the one that had the longest vitality, was "The Faithful Promiser." Originally written with the intention of being sent only to his old friends as a memento of his connexion with the parish he had just left, it found favour with a much larger public who eagerly purchased edition after edition until hundreds of thousands of copies were sold. Next in popularity was his "Morning and Night Watches," which also had an enormous sale, and his "Memories of Bethany," the sale of which ran into many thousands. All the books of this author were more or less successful (and he was a most

voluminous writer), but the sale of the majority has now very greatly decreased, while some are seldom, if ever, inquired for.

Dean Goulburn's "Thoughts on Personal Religion" was once to be found in every bookseller's shop throughout the kingdom, and at the height of its popularity had an annual sale of nearly ten thousand copies; now its circulation is of a very limited character. This was one of the books which Mr. Gladstone generally gave to the young men who were fortunate enough to come within his sphere of influence.

Another author whose books were formerly very popular was Bishop Oxenden. The one which had the biggest sale was "The Pathway of Safety," but most of his works sold by their tens of thousands. Mention should also be made of those by the Rev. Horatius Bonar, especially his "Hymns of Faith and Hope," each volume as it appeared passing through many editions.

The following names will bring back to many readers the titles of books which have been appreciated by young as well as old: the Rev. John Angell James, the Rev. Newman Hall (over a million of the latter's "Come to Jesus" have been disposed of), Miss Havergal, Miss Marsh, the Rev. James Hamilton, the Rev. W. Jay, and the Rev. C.H. Spurgeon. These names represent a few only out of the many writers of religious books which were then popular. Most of them have greatly decreased sales, while others have fallen out altogether and are probably quite unknown to the present generation. There were also issued about this time many religious works published anonymously. These caused a great stir, and met with an extensive demand. Amongst them were "Able to Save," "Pathway of Promise," "Meet for Heaven," "Throne of Grace," "Heaven our Home," but, like the works already noticed, they have also run their course.

The first half of the Victorian era was apparently the Golden Age for religious books, for besides those writers who issued their books independently there was at this period a large number of separate series and libraries in vogue which contained reissues of most of the leading works by the old divines.

To show the variety and range of these issues, a selected few might here be mentioned. The most important amongst them were "The Christian's Family Library." This was under the editorship of the Rev. Edward Bickersteth, and

consisted of about fifty-two volumes, all of a theological character. Another was the "Biblical Cabinet," issued by Clark, of Edinburgh, in forty-six volumes. The "Lady's Closet Library" contained volumes on "The Marys," "The Marthas," "The Lydias," "The Hannahs," etc., of Scripture; "The Christian's Fireside Library," in which were such books as Bigg's "Handbook of Popery" and McIlvaine's "Evidences of Christianity"; "The Library of Christian Biography," edited by Rev. Robert Bickersteth, was another important series, whose general title indicates the class of literature it contained. Under the editorship of such well-known men as Dr. Pye Smith, Robert Southey, and James Montgomery, a series of "Sacred Classics" were very popular: so also was "The London Theological Library," containing such representative works as Lardner's "Credibility of Gospel History" and Milner's "Church of Christ."

The following titles of a few series out of many may be of interest: "Protestant's Sound Literature," "Pickering's Christian Classics," "Library of Puritan Divines," "The Sacred Family Library," "The Spiritual Library," and "The Practical Christian's Library." In most of these libraries there appeared an edition of some of these old-fashioned and now almost obsolete religious books represented by the following titles: Boston's "Crook in the Lot," Sutton's "Learning to Live, and Learning to Die," Ken's "Divine Love," Taylor's "Holy Living and Dying," Watson's "Apology," Baxter's "Saints' Rest," Magee on "The Atonement," Paley's "Evidences," and Law's "Serious Call." Most of these have now a very flickering existence, while for others there is no market whatever. How truly the wise and eloquent words of Bishop Carpenter in his Hulsean Lectures illustrate the reputation and influence of many of the writers of religious books, both ancient and modern, and of the books themselves, some of these having a vitality only during their authors' lives, while others, like their writers, shed influence through succeeding generations. The Bishop says:

"She [History] measures men not by the tawdry reputations of the hour, but by the influence they can diffuse; she watches the circling wave which forms as men cast their force into the great ocean of life, and she measures their power by the life of that wave; and she finds that few—few indeed—have been able to spread their influences beyond their age; she notes many exalted to the skies, and she sees that in the next generation their name is clean put out; she measures the

greatness of men as men do the height of mountains, by the length of the shadows they cast upon the surface of the world; and, measuring thus, she bids those whose influence lives through the ages to sit like gods among the hills of time."

It is intended here to consider only those works or writers which were of a popular character. It would therefore be out of place to record the various volumes of sermons, biographies, or theological treatises on the various systems which have more or less occupied the attention of the religious world, and have to a large extent shaped the character of many of our denominations. In passing, however, it may be of interest to direct attention to that vast array of literature which sprang into existence through the religious controversies which have to a large extent influenced the English Church.

The greatest of these was that known as the Tractarian Movement, and centred round the illustrious names of Keble, Newman, and Pusey. An extensive library might be formed of the works brought forth by this polemic controversy. The publication of "Essays and Reviews," Seeley's "Ecce Homo," Gladstone's "Vatican Decrees," and "Lux Mundi," edited by Canon Gore, also produced a flood of literature which has left an indelible mark on religious thought and practice. To these may probably be traced that diffusion of religious influence which has entered into so many branches of our literature and even to our fiction.

Another branch of religious literature which shows a conspicuous decline is that of "Family Prayers." Years ago, no bookseller's shop would be complete without a copy of Oxenden's, Bickersteth's, Villiers', or Thornton's "Family Prayers"; and such old-fashioned volumes as Hawker's "Daily Portion," "The New Week's Preparation," Jenk's "Devotions," Fletcher's "Family Devotion," and the "Family Prayers" of Toplady and Reven, were all in constant demand. With these are associated a number of volumes of private devotion, Bishop Wilson's "Sacra Privata" and "Pietas Quotidiana" being the most popular. These, like the "Family Prayers," show a great decline both in their production and sale. It is difficult to suggest a reason for this decline other than that of the general evolution in religious thought which is continually changing the course of human progress and action. Religion is undoubtedly the greatest factor in influencing the character of a

nation, so from this foundation there will probably spring up in the future a broad, reasonable, and intelligent class of writings which in their development and thought will be more cosmopolitan than doctrinal, and which will deserve to be classed as English literature.

In comparing the educational literature of this period the changes have also been very great; those were the days when the works edited by Dr. Smith took the lead in the higher branches of education. Colenso's Arithmetic was the most popular book on that subject, while Cornwell's Geography and his other books were great sellers. The "Child's Guide to Knowledge" sold in its thousands, Chambers's educational books were very popular, as were also Brewer's Guides, "Stepping Stones to Knowledge," Weale's Series, Pinnock's, Guy's, and Wilson's Catechisms and Gleig's School Series. Of not quite the same character but greatly used for educational purposes were "Line upon Line" and "Peep of Day." Of the latter, some 250,000 copies were sold in the early days of its publication. Spelling books were then a most important part of educational literature, the most popular being Butter's, but the following also had large sales, Guy's, Mavor's and Vyse's. The copyright of Vyse's sold for £2,500, with an annuity to the author of £50 per year. The change in this class of educational literature has been very great.

It was in 1864 that the Society for Promoting Christian Knowledge announced that their books could now be obtained by booksellers on favourable terms. This was also the first year of the publication of "The Statesman's Year Book," which has had a continuous, and I hope will have a lasting, success. There were also many libraries which had large sales and were very popular. Among them were Hurst and Blackett's, Bentley's Standard Library, Select Library of Fiction, Run and Read Library, Railway Library, Parlour Library, Travellers' Library, Home and Colonial Library, Bohn's Various Libraries, The Cottage Library, consisting of some 300 volumes, Lardner's Scientific Library, and Beale's Sixpenny Library. Most of our older poets had at this period very large sales; but, like other things, there has been a great change in poetry, not only in the style of writing but also in the ideals, which are more lofty and inspiring and are far above such writers as Cowper, Longfellow, Moore, Tupper and others who at this period were very popular.

About this time the following Magazines were started, and they all had a considerable popularity and very large sales, but, strangely enough, they have now all ceased to exist: "The Sunday Magazine," of which over one hundred thousand of the first number was sold, "Good Words," also selling largely, "The Argosy," "Aunt Judy's Magazine," "Belgravia," "London Society," "Tinsley's Magazine," edited by Anthony Trollope, and "The Broadway." Number one had a sale of over 100,000 copies.

In 1865 "The Fortnightly Review" was started under the editorship of G.H. Lewes. From that time onward it has maintained a reputation for scholarly, intellectual and scientific articles and is always up to date upon all subjects of the day.

In looking back, it is interesting to note the change in the character of book illustrations. Formerly, especially at Christmas time, there was a large output of well-illustrated books, principally in black and white, and there were then few illustrations printed in colour. The illustrations of Gustave Doré must take the first place as commanding the greatest public attention. Among other popular illustrators of this period were John Tenniel, Birket Foster, Selous, T. Leighton, G.J. Pinwell, Noel Humphreys, J.E. Millais, John Gilbert, Arthur Hughes, Kate Greenaway, Richard Doyle, A.B. Houghton, Sidney Cooper, and the brothers Dalziel, who were also great producers of the printing blocks.

Another of the leading features of the trade was the immense sale of Birthday Books, from Shakespeare to Tennyson. Every poet with a reputation had a compilation made from his writings for which there was always a receptive public. One of the most fascinating and lasting of juvenile books popular at this time was "Alice's Adventures in Wonderland." The larger part of the first edition of this book was sold to an American publisher so that a second edition could be quickly announced; that was probably a wise policy and helped to draw attention to the value of the book.

During this and the following years, many authors had great reputations which to-day have almost ceased. The books of most of them have long been out of print, and are almost forgotten except by those who lived during the middle of the nineteenth century. I would instance "A.L.O.E.," who had some fifty books in circulation, the author of "Mary Powell," who issued

some twenty-four popular stories, the Rev. J.C. Ryle, Hugh Miller, Mrs. Webb, William and Mary Howitt, Artemus Ward, Mrs. Sewell, R.M. Ballantyne, Samuel Smiles, Miss Yonge, James Grant, Mayne Reid, John Timbs, S. Baring-Gould, Mrs. Carey Brock, Mrs. Gatty, and many others. Some of the novelists who have come to stay had at this period very large sales. Among them, of course, were Dickens, Thackeray, Scott, C. Kingsley, Miss Braddon, Anthony Trollope, George Eliot, and others who, I think, laid a foundation which was very helpful to our later novelists; but it is quite a question whether a new departure is not now developing and that the novel of to-day deals more particularly with the practical events of everyday life and the effect they have upon the moral and spiritual development of the nation.

When Paternoster Square took the place of Newgate Market in 1872, it was quite anticipated that this position would be occupied entirely by publishers and thus form a centre for the trade, but at present this hope has not been realized. During these years great changes took place in Paternoster Row, many of the old buildings giving place to new ones of greater architectural beauty. The following houses are at the present time examples of the improvements which took place by rebuilding: Longmans, Blackwoods, Nelsons, Aldine Chambers. Other changes and improvements are in progress to-day. The Oxford University Press took over the business of the Oxford Bible Warehouse, with what success may be judged by its palatial buildings and business in Amen Corner and Ave Maria Lane, to which it moved in 1883.

There has also been a great change in books besides those previously mentioned, from the superficial gentility of the middle and later part of the Victorian era, to the common-sense practical way we now have of reasoning out the social and political events of the day. This change, if guided by proper thought and consideration for others, will undoubtedly lead to a better and happier England. There are, however, still many changes required, especially in the making and selling of books; and it is to be hoped that by a greater union and more harmony and uniformity in the trade, a more general prosperity will be associated with it, and that many of the disputes and difficulties, often more imaginary than real, will be avoided. It appears to me that the shortest way to attain these ideals will be a central control consisting of representatives of both masters and men in

the publishing and bookselling trade, who will settle disputes and whose aim will be to see that a satisfactory profit is realized by the various interests represented. This question has been more fully dealt with in a later chapter.

The Elementary Education Act which was passed by W.E. Forster in 1870 created a great change in the educational literature of this period, the sum asked for in Parliament in 1871 being about one and a half million pounds. What the future educational grant will be, it is impossible to say, though it is to be hoped that it will make as great an improvement in the people as it has done in educational literature.

Another noticeable fact in connexion with books is the few foreign books—especially French—which are now translated and issued in this country. The following authors at this early period had very large sales: Victor Hugo, Jules Verne, Figuiet, Erckmann-Chatrian and others.

It was in July, 1869, that Simpkin, Marshall & Co. gave their first and last dinner in celebration of the twenty-fifth anniversary of the present building in Stationers' Hall Court, at which the then head of the firm, Mr. John Miles, presided. It was a most social and happy event, and I wish the celebration had been continued. I remember that one of the old hands, William Griffiths, sang a song of his own composition which showed the good feeling then existing between employer and employed. I can only give one of the verses:

"Then here's success to Simpkin's Firm and may they always find,
In studying their interest us ever of one mind;
May their connexion far and wide extend the globe around,
And as each year shall onward roll may all of us be found
In this fine new house I'm singing of,
One of the olden time."

to which I certainly say Amen.

Before Simpkin, Marshall & Co. added to their premises the building which now runs into Ave Maria Lane, these were occupied by a competing wholesale firm named Whittaker & Co. The two houses were on good terms, and, when out of stock of certain books, we could always borrow from our neighbouring firm, which shows that a good feeling existed at this

period even between competitors. This business was taken over by Messrs. W. Kent & Co. in 1876.

CHAPTER IV

Some Further Recollections and Reflections

IN my previous chapter I dealt with many things in the book trade which impressed me more particularly in the first years of my Stationers' Hall Court experience. I will now try to give a brief account of other incidents with which I was associated during some of the following years. These are not stated in chronological order but have been jotted down as they have reappeared in my memory.

One thing which has struck me is to find what a number of publishers during the last fifty years have either ceased to exist or have been incorporated with other firms; many of them being houses of great importance and publishers of a considerable number of popular books. The following are some of the firms which I am able to call to my memory which were then in existence: Messrs. Walton & Maberley, A.W. Bennett, J. Bennett, J. Russell Smith, H. Colburn, John Maxwell (the husband of Miss Braddon), Bradbury, Evans & Co., J.C. Nimmo (the publisher of many beautiful books), Houlston & Wright (the publishers of the Enquire Within series), Groombridge & Son, Rivington & Co. (taken over by Longmans & Co.), J. Masters, W. Hunt, W. Mackintosh, E. Moxon (the early publisher of Tennyson's and Swinburne's works), J. Camden Hotten (who published and introduced into this country Mark Twain, Bret Harte, and Artemus Ward. He died at the age of forty, and his business was taken over by Messrs. Chatto & Windus), J.C. Newby, Saunders & Ottley, Griffith & Farran (the successors to John Newbery), W. Day & Son (high-class printers and publishers), W. Tegg, Hardwick, J. & C. Mozley, A. Strahan (one of the most enthusiastic publishers of his day), Tinsley Bros. (they published for T. Hardy, George Meredith, and Miss Braddon), R. Bentley (his business was taken over by Macmillan in 1898), N. Trübner, and Charles Knight (who died in 1873, aged 81; he was the first publisher of the British Almanac and

Companion and also issued the Penny Cyclopædia and the History of England, with other interesting and educational work), L. Booth, Virtue, R. & A. Suttaby, Smith Elder & Co. (now incorporated with John Murray), and many others. It is also somewhat astonishing what a change has taken place in the character of the books issued by some publishers. To instance a few, Messrs. Cassell & Co. principally issued educational and serial publications, C. Griffin were educational and religious publishers, Messrs. Nelson & Son published mainly juveniles, including a large selection of 1d., 2d., 3d., 4d., and 6d. books. Messrs. W. Collins & Son were also educational and religious publishers.

I should like to place on the other side some of the gains the publishing trade has received, and mention new firms that are among the leaders of the trade to-day. Messrs. Methuen & Co. have by a literary judgment and a judicial trend established one of the leading publishing businesses since the period before mentioned.

In 1894 Mr. W. Heinemann issued his first original popular 6s. novel; this was Sir Thomas Hall Caine's "The Manxman," which not only had a great sale but was a send off such as few publishers have experienced. This novel being first issued in the 6s. form, had a considerable influence in bringing the three-volume novel to an end in 1897. The credit, however, for the original 6s. novel must be given to Mr. Vizetelly, who commenced some ten years earlier the issue of his one-volume 6s. novel series, which contained, beside other important novels, "A Mummer's Wife," by George Moore. Mr. J.M. Dent, in founding the "Every Man Library," made for his firm a name which is known throughout the world. In this he established a library of literary classics in its broader sense, issuing them in every particular worthy of the books produced. He has thus earned the gratitude of students in every country in which the English language is spoken or read. This firm has also produced many works of great literary and epoch-making value.

Important additions to literature, including Fiction, have been made by such firms as Messrs. Hodder & Stoughton, Hutchinson & Co., T. Fisher Unwin, Constable & Co., E. Arnold, G. Harrap, Sidgwick & Jackson, Eveleigh Nash, A. Melrose, T. Werner Laurie, Duckworth, Selwyn & Blount, H. Jenkins, J. Lane, Chatto & Windus, with others, all of whom, it is hoped, have a great future before them. In 1873 the Cambridge University Press

opened their business premises in Paternoster Row; previous to this, Messrs. Rivington & Co. had acted as their London agents.

In 1874 the Oxford University Press began their now very important business under the management of Mr. Frowde. It is now managed by Mr. Humphrey Milford.

I cannot, however, help thinking that there were more books of what may be termed a literary or classical character issued and sold during the early part of my career than there are to-day. It certainly looks as though the publishers of the future will have considerable opportunities of issuing the works of some of the great masters in literature. Whether or not we are to-day producing works of a character which will be sought for and collected by future generations it is difficult to say. There is one thing certain, however, and that is the spirit and desire to collect first editions of special authors was never greater than it is now. Undoubtedly, the desire to write books as well as to read them is an element to be dealt with, and if it were possible for the publisher to be so gifted that he would publish only books that were really worth publishing, much of the rubbish now being issued and which has only an ephemeral sale would never spoil paper and print. We shall, I suppose, never get perfection, but that is no reason why we should not aim at getting it.

Take poetry, for instance. In my young days, Milton, Tupper, Longfellow, Keats, Shelley, Byron, with others, were considered the leading sellers, while Tennyson, W. Morris, Swinburne, Lewis Morris, the Brownings, were fast pushing some of the older poets out of existence and gaining a deserved popularity, which will last for many generations. Tennyson's popularity was such that it was reported that when he changed his publishers from Moxon to Strahan the latter promised to give him annually the sum of £4,500 for the right to publish his books. There are few poets to-day who could command such an arrangement.

Then there is Swinburne, who in one of his volumes had expressed himself somewhat too realistically and was refused further publication by E. Moxon. Some of his later works were issued by J.C. Hotten and afterwards by Chatto & Windus. There are few, if any, publishers to-day who would take up the Moxon attitude, but times have changed for the better.

In 1890 there were 114 volumes of poetry published, in 1891, 146; and I should conclude that from that period up to the beginning of the war, the number issued fluctuated to a very small extent. In the classified analysis of books and new editions published in 1917, poetry and the drama numbered 544, while in 1918 there were 642 published, which shows that the war has had a considerable influence in providing food for the imagination, poetry being frequently a true interpretation of the feelings of the individual as well as of the nation.

The Victorian era was noted for the issue of many books which sent a thrill of excitement through both the religious and intellectual world. It was in 1867 that "Essays and Reviews" was published, and as it contained contributions by some of the leading men of that period, it greatly influenced the tendency towards liberty of thought and helped forward the period when human life and reason should have its consideration as well as the supernatural. Darwin's "Origin of Species" was still a living influence, although published in 1859, and undoubtedly prepared the way for such men as Huxley and Herbert Spencer. It is not too much to say that these, with other books by men of like opinions, created the spirit of reason and toleration which is having its effect upon the life and education of to-day.

The Victorian era has also been termed the age of the novelist. To a certain extent that is true, as we undoubtedly had during Queen Victoria's reign some of the greatest authors of fiction that this nation has ever produced. To confirm this it is only necessary to mention the names of such men as Charles Dickens, W.M. Thackeray, George Meredith, Thomas Hardy, R.D. Blackmore, H.S. Merriman, C. Kingsley, S.R. Crockett, Charles Reade, Anthony Trollope, Wilkie Collins, Charles Lever, Lord Lytton. All of these authors still have a large number of readers and admirers and their circulation has been enormous.

It is perhaps a debatable question whether the female novelists of this period will live as long as the male novelist. Undoubtedly there were many whose works had very important sales, such as Charlotte Brontë, Mrs. Henry Wood, Miss Braddon, Miss Muloch, Miss C.M. Yonge, Edna Lyall, Mrs. Sewell, Mrs. Oliphant, with many others; but I think it very doubtful if

a collected edition, from a literary point of view, of many of these authors will ever be undertaken by a publisher.

At this period the publishing arrangements between this country and America were in a most unsatisfactory condition, there being only a Copyright Act which allowed an American to possess copyright in England while no Englishman could hold copyright in the United States, so that directly a book obtained popularity in either country it was reprinted, much to the loss of both author and publisher. I remember that in America a very popular novel had been published entitled "Arthur Bonnicastle." The American publisher, with the idea of securing copyright in England, had the last chapter printed and published here prior to the publication of the book, but a firm of London publishers, knowing its popularity in America, had printed an edition before hearing of the arrangement for the last chapter. They were therefore compelled to strike out the last chapter, as the copyright in this country had been secured, and issued the book with an explanatory preface exposing the injustice of allowing an American firm to secure copyright in this country while no Englishman could hold copyright in the United States. This action probably helped considerably the passing of the various Copyright Acts which have made it now possible for the authors in each country to obtain greater satisfaction from the results of their labours than they had done in previous years.

It was about 1870 that Edna Lyall's books became very popular, and, being on very friendly terms with Mr. C. Layton, the representative in London of Messrs. Appleton & Co. of New York, I suggested that his firm should reprint this author's books in America. This was done, and they proved a very great success. There was, however, one very satisfactory arrangement between the principal American publishers which I dare say may have existed in this country. This was that any American publisher who was first in the field with an English author was not afterwards interfered with, however popular the author might become. I know this was the case with Edna Lyall, who received considerable sums from her American publishers, although they had no copyright in her books.

In relation to copyright, I will mention a great event which took place in 1912: the closing for ever of the necessary registration at Stationers' Hall of all books published to secure copyright. The original charter was granted in 1557 and varied according to alterations made by Parliament. The old

Copyright Act was limited to seven years after the death of the author, or forty-two years from the date of publication, whichever should be longer. The new Act gave a term of copyright for life and fifty years after. It came into operation on July 1, 1912, and from that date no registration was required.

Though the new Act has undoubtedly many advantages one cannot help regretting that this source of important details respecting titles, authors and other information, has now ceased and that a system which shows the registration of some of Shakespeare's plays, and many other books of which all lovers of English literature are justly proud, is closed for ever. The last book to be registered by the Stationers' Company was "A Guide to the Shops Act," which appears rather an ignominious ending.

One never-to-be-forgotten event took place in 1885, upon the publication of the Revised Version of the Bible. The Oxford & Cambridge University Presses had united in purchasing the publishing rights, for which it was reported they paid some £20,000. The New Testament had been published in 1881, and it was reported that over one million copies were sold within twenty-four hours of its publication, so when the complete Bible was issued the excitement was intense. Numbers could only be supplied in small quantities and for many weeks the greatest anxiety prevailed in the trade. The desire to obtain copies not only for this country but also for our Colonies was very great. Eventually the supply was equal to the demand, but, judging from opinions now occasionally expressed, it does not appear that the revised edition is the final edition. In all probability we shall have a revised edition of the revised version.

While speaking of the Bible, I am proud to be the possessor of a copy of the one hundred copies produced for the Caxton Celebration in 1877. This copy was presented to me by Mr. Frowde, who had so much to do with its production by the Oxford University Press. At a luncheon given after the opening of the Caxton Exhibition, at which Mr. Gladstone, amongst others, was present, he addressed the audience, and, holding up a copy of this edition in his hand, explained how it had been produced. This, he said, was partly performed at Oxford and partly at London. The impression was limited to 100 copies, and not a sheet was worked from the printing press until the clock struck two on the morning of the 30th June, 1877, the day of the luncheon; the copies were then printed, dried, hot pressed and sent to

London by an early train, taken to the binding works of the Oxford warehouse, rolled, folded, rolled again, pressed, collated, sewed, backed, cut, gilt, and excellently bound in morocco, all within twelve hours. The first copy was sent to Mr. Gladstone. The production of such a book in such a short space of time must have created a record. It was a wonderful performance of which the Oxford University Press may be justly proud, and I am very delighted to possess a copy.

Probably there is no other word in the English language that conveys a greater and a more varied meaning than that of Books. Besides reminding us of the books we have known and loved, it also throws the mind back to ancient history and the records handed down to us on Babylonian bricks or Egyptian papyrus. It was said by St. John, some 2,000 years ago, that if all the books had been written which might have been written upon a particular subject, the world itself could not contain them. If the world could not have contained them 2,000 years ago, what would have been the condition of affairs since the introduction of printing?

Records of different nationalities are being continually discovered and printed, and there are few things more fascinating than the knowledge they reveal of ancient history and the manners and customs of the ancient peoples. Recent explorations have greatly added to our knowledge of the past and probably, when some of the Eastern peoples have settled down to peaceable pursuits instead of national war and strife, we shall have given to us from the sands of Asia and Africa, records and information which will astonish the world, for if, as Dr. Keith states, this world has probably been inhabited for some fifteen millions of years it is to be hoped that records of its peoples' lives and habits exist, and that in some way they have been preserved.

Although all lovers of books and literature are interested in these ancient records, I do not intend attempting even a sketch of these fascinating periods of history and literature, but shall deal with a slight summary of a few names of authors, from the time of the first book printed by Caxton in 1474. This was entitled "Recuyell of the Historyes of Troye," which it is said laid a foundation upon which has been built the greatest of all the

elements which will endow the world with civilization. It is generally understood that one hundred different volumes were issued from the Caxton press. It is, I suppose, a somewhat debatable question whether true literature really gained or lost by the introduction of printing; but it is quite certain that its influence for good has been very great. By the making of books, and thus being able to circulate in a cheaper form the old literature and help on the making of the new, it acted as a stimulus for good which developed greatly during the following centuries.

Take the Bible alone; it is to the wide circulation given to it through the introduction of printing that we owe the peace and goodwill that are by degrees permeating the civilized world. We do not know what literature had been destroyed during previous ages, but through the printing press many great authors of the fifteenth and sixteenth century have been preserved and have left for all time works of which the English-speaking race are justly proud. Among these authors are Francis Bacon, Francis Beaumont, William Camden, George Chapman, John Donne, M. Drayton, R. Hakluyt, G. Herbert, Richard Hooker, Ben Jonson, John Knox, John Lyly, Robert Herrick, Christopher Marlowe, Sir Walter Raleigh, William Shakespeare, Sir Philip Sidney, Edmund Spencer, and many others.

The authors of the seventeenth century also contributed largely to the literature of this country, among them being Joseph Addison, Richard Baxter, Sir T. Browne, John Bunyan, the Earl of Clarendon, John Dryden, John Locke, John Milton, Samuel Pepys, Sir W. Temple, Henry Vaughan, Edmund Waller, Isaac Walton, Daniel Defoe, A. Pope, S. Richardson and Jonathan Swift. This list could be largely increased by the addition of many well-known authors of later periods, but undoubtedly the introduction of printing greatly stimulated the love of literature and books which has grown up to the present day.

I have not attempted to give the names of authors who lived during the eighteenth or nineteenth century as many of them are as familiar as household words. During the last and the present century, there have been many authors whose works will be read by generations yet to come, but it is quite a question whether or no a great change has not taken place in the present-day lovers of books, both in the serious reader as well as the lover of lighter literature. Undoubtedly the war has not only made people think, but has made them reason upon the why and the wherefore of things. I

cannot help feeling that the future of literature as well as that of daily life will have to be viewed from more solidly scientific foundations, and people will want books in which the facts of life are interwoven with the everyday possibilities of life and much of the supernatural imaginings will have gone for ever. Future authors have a great source in the present to draw upon in the moral and physical as well as the ideal life. Those who have the clearest ideas upon these points will be those whose works will be handed down to the generations yet to come. These views are not so much from the authors' point of view, as of one who has been associated with books and has watched events for over sixty years. During that period there have been many and important changes in the character of books as well as of public opinion with regard to them. I anticipate, however, that greater changes are possible in the near future.

From my own observation I cannot help feeling that the future of making and selling books, apart from authorship, will involve many changes. What a great influence must have been exercised by the sending out to the trenches and to all the various departments and agencies connected with the war, the millions of books and miscellaneous reading matter to those engaged in the war. Few people realize to what an enormous extent this was done. It was officially stated that in January, 1919, the Camps Library dispatched to France 129,000 novels, and 60,000 other publications were forwarded regularly every week. These are in addition to those sent out by the American Government and by the Y.M.C.A. and other agencies, and as there will be more money earned in the future by the people generally than there has ever been before, it is to be hoped that they will spend some of it upon books.

What I shall hope to see is that every place which is established for public recreation or instruction has a well-selected library and reading-room. We can only speculate upon the good this would do, although I am firmly convinced that the great work which the Free Libraries have done, and are still doing, will be largely extended. Our young people must have some place of interest to which they can always go. Then we shall be a happier and more contented people. Besides this, the author with high and noble ideals will have some object in producing works which help to nobler thoughts and aspirations, works which lead to a higher and better life. Books enable us to realize our lives and make us feel the wonder and

mystery of the world, they widen our horizon and create a sympathy with humanity. The influence of literature marks the growth of liberty and joy.

The buying and selling of books is a delightful occupation. The bookseller in his work lives in a bygone world as well as in the present. Speaking for myself, I know what a comfort it is in old age to have an exhaustless treasury in books, to have the best in life of all the ages to fall back upon. The man who gives up his work to enjoy old age has nothing to fear if his mind is enriched by knowledge of the best in life and can enjoy the sympathy and friendship of books.

My own love of books was the cause of my entering to a small extent into authorship. Besides occasionally contributing to our trade journals, I also wrote articles in the "Encyclopædia Britannica" on publishing, etc., and also in "The Nineteenth Century," "The Fortnightly Review," and other journals. Some of these I afterwards collected in a volume which I published in 1912 under the title of "The Fascination of Books." I have also issued volumes entitled "The Pleasure of Literature and the Solace of Books," "Saunterings in Bookland," and others. I have also published yearly since 1903, a little "Friend to Friend Kalendar," to which each year I have contributed a poem on Friendship. This has not only had a large circulation, but has brought me many letters of appreciation and added to my many friendships.

The trade of the bookseller, as we now know him, has gradually developed from the early part of the last century. Until then the bookseller either largely printed, or in association with other publisher-booksellers joined in producing, many of the books they sold, the various bookselling partners whose names were on the title page sometimes numbering over twenty different firms. The making and selling of books has now developed into many different channels. There is the Author, the Author's Agent, the Publisher, the wholesale Distributor, and lastly, but not the least important, is the Bookseller. These various mediums through which most books must pass, have to be considered, particularly as regards terms, and although a book may cost little in its production, there are many expenses to be considered before its selling price can be fixed. This has led to much dissatisfaction during the past fifty years, and although arrangements entirely satisfactory to the trade generally have not yet been made, it is now in a more flourishing condition than it has ever been. What I think is now required is the formation of a Booksellers' Central Committee, of which

Authors, Publishers, and Booksellers should become members. This would exclude the Author's Agent and every one not directly connected with the trade of bookselling, as printers, binders and others have their own organizations. Committees of each branch of the trade should be formed to deal with all trade technicalities, but discussions by the members in Council would be allowed upon any departmental difficulty, and the decision of the whole body accepted as final.

In connexion with this body, an arrangement might be made whereby the trade assistants could have a separate establishment for educational and other matters connected with the trade. They should have the power of electing a certain number of members to represent them when any Trades Union or other difficult question came up for general consideration. The future is full of difficulties, and it is only through friendly discussions among the various representatives of all departments of the bookselling trade that these difficulties can be satisfactorily settled.

The need for some progressive alteration in the trade must be apparent to every one associated with it, especially when we look back for some fifty years and remember the difficulties that then existed respecting the giving of discounts to the public, and then consider how during the terrible war now brought to a close and in the years since, the question of discounts has seldom arisen. Those who remember the difficulties which the discount system caused at the before-mentioned period will feel thankful for the part taken in its abolition by the united action of the Publishers' and Booksellers' Associations, and especially by the general establishment of the net book system and in many cases the doing away with the odd copy. But this subject has been more fully dealt with in the chapter on Underselling.

It is, however, only by trade organization that difficulties which must in future arise can be solved, and it is to be hoped that it will further the interest of the assistants and the younger members of the trade so that instead of that want of knowledge which we often hear expressed, we shall have men engaged who are worthy of their craft, and with altered surroundings bookselling, if not regarded as a profession, may be considered as an occupation of light and leading.

I have not dealt here with what is known as the second-hand bookseller. He is the one individual in our trade whom I envy. It is true that while he deals

with the books of the past the ordinary bookseller deals with those of the present, and those to come. His knowledge, however, of his particular branch of trade is, I think, wonderful, for not only does he know the history of a book from its birth to its place upon his shelves, but a little conversation with him and a walk round his shop and the taking down some of the books from their shelves, is sufficient to make any book-lover forget this world in the pleasure and imaginings of those precious treasures which to know is to revere.

CHAPTER V

Some Personal Associations

I HAVE entitled this chapter "Some Personal Associations," and will first speak of a great and happy event which was only ended after forty-three years of married life.

It was in 1868 that I became engaged and in 1870 married, a marriage for which no man ever had more cause to be thankful than myself, owing to the true happiness of my married life, the sympathy, kind thought and consideration of my late wife. In fact, everything which goes to make this life worth living was mine, or I may say ours.

Like everything earthly, alas! it came to an end; but while memory lasts it will never be forgotten. Recalling all this, while thankful for a very happy past, I face what is left to me of the future with a thankful heart. I am also thankful for my dear children, who have all taken up their positions in life and are battling with its duties. They are to me an inexpressible comfort and a blessing, and I can only hope they will pass through and enjoy their lives as much as I have done mine.

I should like to refer here to one other great event in my life, that of becoming a Managing Director of Simpkin, Marshall, Hamilton, Kent & Co., Ltd., in 1894. My great aim in life had always been to climb the ladder of prosperity as far as I possibly could.

While speaking of Simpkin, Marshall & Co., I may mention a few traditional facts regarding the origin and development of that important firm in its connexion with the bookselling trade. Its originator and founder was Mr. Benjamin Crosby, whose descendants are now represented by the firm of Messrs. Crosby, Lockwood & Co., and whose predecessors were in past years partners of Simpkin, Marshall & Co. Mr. Benjamin Crosby came from Yorkshire to London and was apprenticed to a bookseller, James Nunn, in Great Queen Street; he afterwards worked for George Robinson, who was then considered the "King of Booksellers"; finally, he took over the business of Mr. Stalker in Stationers' Hall Court, whose premises were then situated upon the same ground as the buildings now occupied by Simpkin, Marshall, Hamilton, Kent & Co. After an attack of paralysis in 1814, Mr. Benjamin Crosby parted with his business to W. Simpkin and R. Marshall. I have always understood that Simpkin was a hatter in Bridge Street, Blackfriars, and, having capital, he associated himself with Marshall, who was an assistant of Benjamin Crosby.

They, however, took over only the London trade portion of the business, the country portion going to Baldwin, Cradock & Joy. This firm failed in 1837, and the country portion of the old firm came into the hands of Simpkin, Marshall & Co.

In 1829 Simpkin retired from the business, and the financial management of the firm was taken over by Mr. John Miles, senior, under whose supervision very satisfactory results were obtained. Mr. Miles was also associated with the publishing business of Joseph Johnson of St. Paul's Churchyard, who issued the works of the poet Cowper, the critical writings of Priestley, and other important works. Being thus connected with bookselling, Mr. Miles placed his two elder sons in important positions in the trade. The one, named after his father, entered the firm of Simpkin, Marshall & Co., and Mr. Joseph Johnson Miles, evidently named after his publisher friend, entered the firm of Hamilton, Adams & Co. Later on, two other sons of Mr. John Miles, senior, entered the firm of Simpkin, Marshall & Co., and still later several grandsons became partners in the two separate firms before mentioned.

The same traditions of business were continued and carried on for nearly eighty years. It is rather remarkable that, in the period which followed, an amalgamation should take place in 1889 between these two firms and

Messrs. W. Kent & Co., and that, after so many years of competition, they should be brought together into one trading company.

In the busy whirl of Stationers' Hall Court, though there was little opportunity for humour, something occasionally happened that permeated the whole house with amusement, such as when a mistake had been made and one of the partners tried to find out who had made it. However, not being able to discover the offender, he came at last to the most humorous man in the house and tried to fasten it upon him but failed. "Well," he said, with energy, "I must hang somebody." After a pause, the answer came: "Hang me, sir; I want a rise." With a smile the principal left the room and nothing more was heard of the mistake.

Many such incidents have occurred, but they have been lost by the hurrying on of time. This subject, however, has been dealt with in an article entitled "Bookselling and some of its Humours," in my volume on "The Fascination of Books," published in 1912.

Among my later duties at Stationers' Hall Court was that of superintending the purchase, or, as it is termed, the subscription of new books. Every new book issued from the various publishers was first submitted to Simpkin, Marshall & Co., and the number they bought often governed the numbers purchased by the various members of the trade. These varied according to the author's reputation and the sales of their previous issues, and in many cases from a small number to many hundreds were usually ordered. I remember on one occasion a 6s. book by a popular novelist was submitted to us and an order given for 12,000 copies. October is undoubtedly the most important publishing month of the year, and upon many days during that period, between 150 to 200 different books have frequently been offered for subscription.

In 1917 I retired from the position of a Managing Director, but still remain one of the Directors of the Company. It is to me a very great pleasure to be still associated with a house to which I owe so much and occasionally to see the many valued friends with whom I have been associated for over fifty years. Although I have nominally ceased to be a bookseller yet I have several connexions which I hope will keep me in touch with the trade as long as I live. Besides being a Director of Simpkin, Marshall, Hamilton, Kent & Co., Ltd., I have been for many years Chairman of Messrs. Henry

Williams & Co. (Old Bailey), Ltd., also a Director of Messrs. C.W. Faulkner & Co., Ltd., and other companies, so I am still anything but an idle man.

Although this chapter may appear somewhat egotistical, during my life in London I have been connected with many trade and other associations which have been more or less of a personal as well as of an interesting character, and I mention these facts to show that I have not been indifferent to or wanting in sympathy with the various undertakings in which I am concerned.

My first experience was in joining the Committee of the Early Closing Association, then in quite an elementary condition. Like many other Associations which have had small beginnings, it has worked its way through storm and sunshine and has done, and is still doing, much useful work. At the present moment, it is one of the great helpful influences in bettering the condition of the worker. At one of our meetings, held, I think, at St. James's Hall, I had the honour of being on the platform with Anthony Trollope, the great novelist, and John McGregor of Rob Roy fame, who each made delightfully interesting speeches which helped greatly to popularize the Association. I always felt an interest in young men's associations, and joined one while living near Highbury. It was at this time that what was then called Mock Parliaments were usually one of the items in the season's programme.

At one of these gatherings with which I was associated, I little thought what a prominent position its leading speakers would hold in the future. The debate on this occasion was a vote of want of confidence in Lord Beaconsfield's Foreign policy, as just then there was much opposition and discontent respecting his actions. This vote of censure was moved by Lawson Walton, who was destined to become Attorney-General; the present Sir Robert Perks seconded the resolution. The Chairman or Speaker for the occasion was Sir Clarence Smith, recently one of the Sheriffs of the City of London. Needless to say, the motion was carried unanimously. It is pleasant to look back upon the day of small things and to see the development of lives that are useful both in their surroundings and to the state.

Another interesting Association was that of the University Extension, of the Finsbury Park branch of which I was Chairman for several years. During

the autumn of one of our sessions, it was suggested that we should ask Chevalier Marconi, who was just then beginning to be known as an inventor of some new method of telegraphy, to give us a demonstration of his wireless process. He agreed to do so, but little did we think what would be the result of this system and what wonderful influence his discovery would have upon the civilised world.

As Chairman, it was my pleasurable duty to receive Chevalier Marconi, and I was greatly surprised to find so young and apparently inexperienced a person. A few minutes' conversation, however, soon showed that he had a firm foundation for the subject which he was developing. We had arranged to get communication between Highgate and New Southgate, where we were holding the demonstration. Unfortunately, the poles for dispatching the messages to be sent from Highgate did not arrive in time, so we had to content ourselves with having the messages sent from a field close by. Everything worked to our entire satisfaction, and various messages were received stamped in accordance with the Morse system. Whenever there is any further development of the Marconi system I look back upon this meeting with considerable interest and satisfaction. Since then, I have met Chevalier Marconi on various occasions, and he has always struck me as a man of a great personal character and solid determination. One thing which I remember to have heard him say was that "My father was an Italian and my mother an Irishwoman, but I call myself an Englishman"; and I am sure he is one of whom we are all proud.

My association with politics began with my early years at home, when I watched my father, carrying the Union Jack, marching at the head of the voters in our village to the polling booth. Although father was not in any way a public man, he knew what progress meant and was always on that side. I do not remember any political influence being exercised upon me in my young days, and appeared naturally to drift into the ranks of Liberalism, a drifting which I have never regretted. Being an active student of parliamentary events, shortly after coming to London, I obtained admission to the Strangers' Gallery at the House of Commons, and soon felt a keen interest in politics and often afterwards visited the House. I have many times walked to Islington from the Houses of Parliament at two o'clock in the morning after having listened to some interesting debate. I have heard Gladstone, Disraeli, and most of the party leaders in both Houses. I was in

the Gallery of the House of Commons when W.E. Forster was carrying through the Elementary Education Act and the Vote by Ballot Bill. These were opposed, for the Conservative Party, by the then Sir Stafford Northcote, and, although my mind was quite made up as to their desirability, when hearing the eloquence and arguments from the other side, without a strong opinion one might have been easily carried over to the Opposition.

In 1888 I greatly enjoyed a visit to the House, on the occasion when Mr. Ritchie, as he then was, brought in the Bill to create the London County Council. Mr. Gladstone sat on the Opposition Bench with Sir James Stansfeld, the Member for Halifax and the President of the Local Government Board in the previous Liberal Administration. As Mr. Ritchie unfolded his scheme, both Mr. Gladstone and Sir James Stansfeld were busy taking notes. When the main details of the Bill had been explained, they both ceased, being apparently satisfied with the scope of the Bill. As soon as Mr. Ritchie sat down, Mr. Gladstone rose. In a short and eloquent speech, he complimented the hon. gentleman on his proposed Bill and said that although he might suggest some amendments in Committee, they, as a party, quite approved of the principles of the Bill. Owing to Mr. Gladstone's statement, what was expected to be a hot party debate ended in a satisfactory agreement. Even after such interesting proceedings as these, I have always felt that the anticipation of a debate in Parliament is greater than the pleasure realized.

This Bill was eventually passed, and among the candidates for membership of the new London County Council was Lord Rosebery, who stood for the City of London. I had the pleasure of hearing him address several meetings, and, although from a public point of view he was a comparatively young man, he spoke with great thought and feeling, always carrying his audience with him. He was of course returned, and was elected the first Chairman of this important Council.

Notwithstanding that nearly all my life I have been more or less associated with politics, and for over forty years have been upon the register of voters, I have never voted on the winning side except on the occasion when Mr. A.J. Balfour stood for the City of London. I still hope I may do so before I die.

It was in the year 1885, after the passing of the Redistribution Bill, that I became more closely associated with politics. By this Redistribution Act, Middlesex (for many years it had been represented by two members) was divided into seven constituencies. I joined the Liberal Association in Hornsey, one of the new divisions, and the one in which I then lived, and from that time onwards took an active part in their proceedings. On the eve of the first elections in these divisions, we had a big send-off meeting of the Middlesex candidates at the Holloway Hall, at which the great Liberal veteran Mr. Samuel Morley presided. Many leading politicians were present, including Sir Charles Dilke, Mr. W.S. Caine, Mr. Alfred Milner (now Viscount Milner), who stood for the Harrow Division, Mr. S.D. Waddy, and others. Great enthusiasm prevailed, but the success at the polling booth was not as great as we anticipated, and the Hornsey Division returned a Conservative, which it continued to do until a fresh division of Middlesex took place under the Act of 1918. Mr. Carvel Williams, the champion for Disestablishment of the Church, was our president; he was a most able and eloquent speaker, full of work and energy and equal to any emergency, but although we had occasionally such speakers as Mr. Asquith, Mr. Lloyd George, and other leading politicians of that day, success at the poll was never obtained.

I was for many years chairman of the Council, and that brought me in touch with many men of light and leading. I was, however, compelled to give it up, as so many other duties had a more special call upon my time. In 1904 I was induced to join the non-political party which was standing for the London County Council Division of Stoke Newington, and was returned.

And here let me state that I have a great objection to party feeling in local affairs. It is quite bad enough when carried to extremes in parliamentary contests, but local affairs should be dealt with entirely from the local point of view of what is best and from none other. Having made many new friends and being elected to the Library Committee, I found myself in my element amongst books. Before the Free Library was started at Stoke Newington, with my good friend Mr. A.W. Mackenzie, I originated a private Free Library in the Finsbury Park District, and although this library was not very large it was very serviceable. It was carried on by voluntary aid and contributions, and, in accordance with the Act passed in 1892, afterwards taken over by the Council of Stoke Newington.

When this Free Library was opened, thanks to the Carnegie Trust, I had the honour of seeing my name engraved with others on a stone tablet as a record of those who were associated with the founding of it. My relations with Stoke Newington were always of the most pleasant character, as there were many book lovers on the Committee, among them being Mr. Wynne Baxter and Mr. Charles Welsh, the noted City Librarian.

It was during my membership of the Stoke Newington Council that I received tickets of invitation to the inauguration of the L.C.C. Passenger Steamboat Service on the Thames, which had been constructed at an outlay of nearly £300,000. Our present King, with some of the young Princes, headed the fleet of steamers which went from Temple Pier to Greenwich and back. Altogether it was a most pleasant trip, but events followed which brought this venture to an end, a decision from many points of view much to be regretted. It occurs to me, however, that if more attention were given to the banks of the Thames by building an Embankment on the south side similar to that on the north side, there is no reason why it should not eventually become in every way as attractive as the rivers which flow through so many of the Continental cities.

About this time I became a member of the New Vagabond Club, and enjoyed for many years the various dinners given to some of the leading men of the time. These were usually held at the Hotel Cecil, and I have known over 500 ladies and gentlemen to be present on some of the important occasions. The Club was very cosmopolitan: Bishops, Members of Parliament, the theatrical profession, authors—in fact, anyone who was then in the public eye was certain to receive an invitation to some of the dinners. When this club became incorporated with the old Playgoers' Club, many, like myself, felt that these Sunday festivities did not quite fall in with their ordinary way of spending the day of rest, and I was compelled to retire from it.

Another association of which I am particularly proud to be one of the vice-presidents, is the Booksellers' Provident Institution, and the Booksellers' Provident Retreat; the former I joined in 1869, and for over fifty years have been an active member on its committees. This great institution was inaugurated on February 15, 1837, at Stationers' Hall, and during the greater part of its existence it has had for its president some one representing either the house of Longman or Murray. It is an institution of which every

member is proud, and should be more appreciated in the trade than it is, for it has done, and is still doing, work of great value to its necessitous members.

The opening ceremony of the Booksellers' Retreat took place in 1846. The great novelist Lord Lytton presided, and a sum of £800 was collected. At this Retreat there are seven pleasantly situated houses occupied either by members or their widows, and the occupants of these houses, owing to the funds at the disposal of the Committee, have their lives not only extended but made thoroughly happy and comfortable.

In 1872 there was a great effort made by many of the London Booksellers' Assistants to found an institution which would be always open to its members for educational and social purposes. The proposal met with support, and much discussion upon details took place; but the only decision arrived at was that it should be called the Booksellers' Literary Institution. After many meetings and discussions it was given up and the committee dissolved. It was a noble object, and I sincerely hope that in the future some such organization will come into existence, for it is badly wanted both for the assistants and the trade generally.

In 1898 I had the honour of being elected a member of the Worshipful Company of Stationers, which is so associated, especially in the past, with literature and books. I am sure every one who takes the opportunity of going through the Hall will feel proud of this almost sacred building. It has a history connected with the makers and distributors of literature which is an honour not only to the trade but to the nation; I sincerely hope that the policy now being advocated by the City Livery Club, of which I am also a member, that of more closely associating the various Livery Companies with the trade or craft by which they are designated, will be successful. If this can be done, it will be better for the various City Guilds, as well as the particular trades after which the Guilds are named.

In 1897 the Prince of Wales, afterwards King Edward VII, inaugurated the Hospital Fund which still bears his name, to commemorate the sixtieth year of Queen Victoria's reign. One of the means adopted to assist in raising funds was the issue of a series of stamps which varied in price. This series met with great success, and the public issue of the stamps was entrusted to Simpkin, Marshall & Co. After it had run its course and added considerably

to the Hospital funds, it was decided by the authorities that the issue should be discontinued, and that the plates from which the stamps had been printed should be destroyed. A special day was fixed for this purpose, and our present King and Queen, then the Prince and Princess of Wales, kindly consented to undertake this task. The destruction of the plates took place at the Bank of England in a small room, and another Director of our Company and myself were selected to see the operation completed. It was a most interesting occasion, and, being in so small and informal a place, the talk between the half-dozen or so witnesses and the Royal destroyers was very pleasant. With a strong file which was handed to her, the Princess of Wales, in a most business-like way, rubbed the face of the metal plates of the stamps and thereby made it impossible for any more to be printed. Though it all happened in a very short space of time, it was a delightful as well as an historic gathering.

While speaking of Royalty, I am reminded of an occasion when Edward VII, then Prince of Wales, opened the Free Library at Lambeth under the Chairmanship of Mr. Tate, who contributed largely to the Library funds. The Prince made an excellent speech, short and to the point, although his articulation was not very clear. This, I suppose, arose through the many languages which it was necessary for him to master, and it struck me at the time that his accent was more like that of a foreigner who had learned English than an Englishman's.

On the issuing of the eleventh edition of the "Encyclopædia Britannica," I was asked by the editor to write two articles on Bookselling and Publishing, with biographical notices of British and American publishers' houses. I did this with much pleasure, and afterwards received an invitation to a dinner at the Hotel Cecil to celebrate the Encyclopædia's completion and publication. Among some 600 guests who were present, there were representatives of great distinction from every department of learning, such as the Speaker of the House of Commons, Mr. Balfour, Sir W. Harcourt, Lord Brassey, Lord Bryce and Viscount Wolseley. These names are sufficiently representative of the guests, although it would be difficult to give a complete list of them. Altogether, it was a wonderful gathering, and my association with it was most gratifying to me.

CHAPTER VI

The Bookselling Trade and Underselling

THE published price of a book being publicly advertised, there is probably no other trade which gives the same opportunity of attracting the public by underselling as that of Bookselling, and evils of a greater or less degree in this direction have been practised since the days of Caxton. In the early days of the nineteenth century serious attention was directed to underselling, and an association formed entitled "The Associated Booksellers." This was formed in 1812, but the notorious Lackington carried underselling, and what he termed "remainders," to such an extreme that the very existence of the Bookselling trade was seriously threatened. This Association, however, lacked sufficient strength to take the necessary steps to stop the underselling mania, and it was not until 1850 that another Booksellers' Association was formed which nobly fought a most difficult and trying battle. The Association failed, owing to the decision in 1852 by Lord Campbell, Mr. Grote, and Dean Milman that the question of a bookseller having "paid the purchase money shall not resell it under a certain price, derogated from the rights of ownership which, as purchaser, he had acquired." This decision had the effect of dissolving the Association.

Some years after attention was again directed to the evil of underselling, which it has taken nearly a century to bring to an end, for it is hoped that by the adoption of publishing on the net book system and the Publishers' and Booksellers' Associations, discounts to the public will be entirely abolished. On looking through the volume for 1864 of that consistently intelligent trade journal, "The Bookseller," I find the editor saying that "The opening of the new season appears to be a very appropriate time for a few remarks upon the ruinous system of underselling, which seems to be the rule rather than the exception, not only in London, but in most provincial cities. How far it will proceed and what may be the extent of the damage it may do, none can predict. We, however, believe underselling to be wholly unnecessary and that it may be checked, if not altogether stopped, if publishers and booksellers will come to an understanding on the subject." The article goes on to point out how by publishers, if necessary, reducing their selling prices, they might do away with the discount allowed to the public, or, in other words, encourage the adoption of a net system. It is

pleasant to see a letter on this point issued the same year, and signed by A. Macmillan. When about to publish their celebrated Globe edition of Shakespeare's works at 3s. 6d., after speaking of the number of pages, the quality of the paper, the printing and the binding, Mr. Macmillan goes on to say, "Why should the trade throw away their profits on a book that needs no further cheapening to put it within the reach of all. I have neither the will nor the power to dictate to the trade what they shall sell the books for after they buy them from us, but I would be glad and grateful if they would try the experiment on this new book whether the underselling which has crept in of late years, does good really to anybody." It is most gratifying that the present head of that firm should have done so much to bring to an end the unjust system of discounts. It was stated that nearly 80,000 copies of the Globe Shakespeare were sold within six months of its publication.

In 1867, after many years of unrest, matters were again brought under discussion through Mr. Thomas Bosworth, of Regent Street, giving excessive discounts. I have before me a leaflet issued by this bookseller entitled "Rattening in the Book Trade." In this leaflet he complains of Messrs. Hamilton, Adams & Co. having closed his account, owing to his continuing to sell to the public books at trade prices and sometimes less than that. This did not continue very long, as I find that in 1869 he had to make a composition with his creditors. In 1890 the parent of the Associated Booksellers of Great Britain and Ireland was formed, under the title of "The London Booksellers' Society," and I am proud to record that I was one of the early members of its Council. The main object of the Society was to restrict discounts to 25 per cent., and it issued a price list from 6d. to £2 2s. showing these discounts. Had it not been for the introduction of the net system, this Booksellers' Association would in all probability have followed the footsteps of its predecessors.

A correspondent in "The Bookseller" for 1877 gives a very despondent account of the bookseller and the way the bookselling trade was carried on. This despondency was caused mainly by the iniquitous system of discounts which were then being given to the public and the unfair methods of business, owing to the want of harmony and business regulations. The correspondent says that "A bookseller of to-day is very often a man who might just as well be a cheese-monger or a pork-butcher for anything he knows or cares about books; and as for him being capable of guiding or

advising his customers, they have sometimes no little trouble in making him understand a requirement that lies just outside the current of popular demands. The cause of this degeneracy is not far to seek: it is the undignified and unneighbourly scramble for custom, in which each man's object is to give away a larger discount in the shilling than anyone else. Unless booksellers can be found who will have the courage to stand out of this scramble and be content to serve such customers who are willing to pay a fair price for their books, it is to be feared that the race of booksellers will become extinct." Fortunately, by the introduction of the net system, this downward tendency has been stopped, and the bookselling trade is gradually taking the place it deserves in the world of letters.

The Publishers' Association was established in 1896. Mainly through the influence and the exertions of Sir Frederick Macmillan, the net book scheme was officially recognized by the Publishers' Association. It has grown ever since that time and has undoubtedly been the salvation of the Bookselling trade in this country, and it is hoped that it will lead to further and better conditions for every one connected with the trade.

This question of underselling is so closely associated with the general condition of the Bookselling trade that I have decided to reprint in this chapter the following article which appeared in the "Publishers' Circular" and was written by me in 1915. Though a development in some of the particulars has been obtained, there is still much to be done. As the article was reprinted and distributed by the Associated Booksellers, and I also receive so many congratulatory letters respecting it, I feel that it may probably be of service when some of the details of the trade are again under discussion. I have omitted from the article such portions of it as time has shown to be unnecessary. What I have here reprinted I hope may be found of interest.

SOME NOTES ON BOOK-SELLING

In using the term "bookselling," it is intended in this article to include all those businesses, exclusive of authorship, which are interested in the making, distribution, and selling of books, and while offering a few suggestions to these trade organizations, there will be no attempt to dogmatize on any particular sphere of it. As their working conditions are so continually changing, these must therefore fall in with modern

requirements or give place to others which can accommodate themselves to the altered conditions.

Since the origin of printing there have been differences and grievances, many of them imaginary, in connexion with the trade of bookselling. Some of these complaints are characterized as a decay of the author, the book, or the bookseller; sometimes it is the over-production of books or their cheapness, due to underselling or to outside firms being allowed to trade in them, but all these complaints either die a natural death or turn out to have little foundation, and the trade goes on in much the same way as it has done for centuries past. There is occasionally a reason for some of these criticisms, and although there have been variations in both the production and the distribution of books, yet many of the salient features remain the same as those existing in the early days of bookselling.

Before suggesting a solution of some of the difficulties which we find current in the bookselling trade to-day, let us inquire into that of book production.

Foremost among the real or imaginary difficulties is the question of over-production. This is, from many points of view, an important question with distributors of books, both wholesale and retail.

Take the following interesting particulars, which appear somewhat out of harmony with our unsatisfactory means of distribution, but when we compare these figures with those of other countries, they seem insignificant: In the year 1913, 9,541, and in 1914, 8,863 new books were published in England. In 1913, 10,607, and in 1914, 10,175 new books were published in America. In the year 1912, 34,801 new books were published in Germany, and in 1913 no fewer than 35,078 were issued from their various presses. Nearly four times as many books were thus yearly produced in Germany as in England—but it must be admitted that many of these are of a local or ephemeral character—and over three times as many as in America. A comparison between the number of authors and their proportion to the population is no less surprising. In 1910, there were 9,000 writers of books in America; there were 8,000 in Great Britain; while in Germany there are over

31,000 of such *littérateurs*. Of course, the war has greatly changed these figures.

It is computed that the total number of printed books in the world is no less than 11,638,810, and that about 8,714,000 of these have been published subsequently to the year 1800. From 1500 to 1535 the number of books produced annually averaged only 1,250. It was not until 1700 that the annual average passed 10,000, and it was not until 1887 that it reached 100,000. From 1900 to 1908, however, the world's annual output averaged 174,375. Some interesting statistics relating to the production of printed books are given in the "Bulletin de l'Institut International de Bibliographie."

The complaint of over-production is almost as old as the art of printing itself, for, according to Charles Knight's "The Old Printer," it is stated that some Roman printers of the Latin Classics in 1471 petitioned the Pope to interfere on their behalf. In their petitions they stated that "they were the first who introduced this Art, with vast labour and cost, into His Holiness's territory, and encouraged by our example, other printers have done the same. If you peruse the Catalogue of the books printed by us, you will admire how and where we could produce a sufficient quantity of paper or even rags for such a number of volumes. The total of these books amount to 12,475, a prodigious heap, and intolerable by reason of those unsold. We are unable to bear the expense of housekeeping for want of buyers, of which there cannot be a more flagrant proof than that our house is full of quire books, but void of every necessary of life."

From this it would appear that the question of over-production has an early origin and is continually being repeated, but I dare venture the remark that there is not now or never has been any over-production in books that are worth putting on the market, and if publishers would refuse the bribes offered by those anxious to see their names in print, and only issue such books as in their mature judgment they consider worth putting before a community of intelligent readers, there would be less outcry of over-production. This question is very far-reaching, and especially affects the sellers of books. Frequently the publishers issue books, the cost being paid by an ambitious author; but for this the public would probably never hear of him; the book is shown to the

trade, no reference whatever is made to its origin, and booksellers are often led to buy and stock a book by their trust in the publisher, and find out to their cost that there is no demand whatever for the book, and it remains upon their shelves. It is a fair contention that the bookseller should be warned against such books, in which the publishers have taken no risks, neither should the booksellers be persuaded into so doing. Undoubtedly, if the trade is to prosper, there must be more discrimination in selecting stock. There are now so many influences at work to advertise a book: not only are there the ordinary media, but an author will go round to the booksellers, talking about his book, telling them it will sell in thousands, and that there has never been such a book written before. Instances have been known where the author has gone to a number of booksellers and ordered copies of his book, never calling or paying for them. The bookseller, by these means, has to put into his stock books which he is unable to sell. There should for safety be a method of allowing returns to be made of such books before the publishers make up their accounts; there would then be an inducement for a bookseller to display a book upon his counter or in his window, with a possibility of sales being made through the publicity given to the book.

Many books are published for which no reasonable market exists, but as long as education continues to influence the mind there will be found persons who think their ideas are inspired, and they must give them expression in the printed book. There is to-day a larger reading public than ever, and the all-important point is how to get hold of them. On this point much has been written and said. It is of no use discussing the old methods, so much extolled, of how the bookseller formerly lived over his shop and existed with, if not by, his books, and what men of encyclopædic knowledge these ancients were. These times are gone, and the men are gone with them. We must, therefore, deal with events as they are to-day. Every one engaged in the business of bookselling would no doubt confess that he is out, *inter alia*, to try and make money and earn a living, and this is one of the points I wish to discuss. First, the men who constitute the bookselling trade are probably as intelligent and as up to date in knowledge as they were in the past. It has been said that the second-hand bookseller is the only man with a knowledge of books, but this is not so. Unfortunately, the

exigence of our social life often prevents him from giving as much attention to his trade as formerly. This has been intensified by the margin of profit not being commensurate with the labour; therefore in many cases other kindred businesses have been added to that of bookselling.

Undoubtedly the greatest benefaction which has ever fallen to the book trade was the introduction in January, 1900, of the net system. By this system a reasonable profit was guaranteed, and members of the book trade were brought together and the trade organized and extended in a manner which would have been impossible without some such rallying point as that offered by the net system. This has now obtained such a hold, both upon the trade and the public, that it must remain one of the axioms of the bookselling trade.

A similar system was started in America in 1901, and for many years considerably helped the publishers in that country in organizing the trade, and protecting that of the bookseller in his attempt to remedy some of the evils caused by undersellers and unfair competition. Unfortunately, an adverse decision in the American Supreme Court in what is known as the "Macy case," caused the members of the Association to wind up their organization. This was done at the end of 1914.

In these days of increased business pressure and competition, it appears especially unfortunate that so large and important an organization affecting the publishing trade in America should so suddenly come to an end. It is, however, hoped that the publishers will be able before long to reconsider the situation and establish in some form or other a new representative organization to take charge of and to promote the general interests of the American publishing and bookselling trades, for, undoubtedly, without some such central control, the trade of bookselling cannot thrive in the same manner as it otherwise would do.

A very important point is the relation of the publishers one to the other. If there were more trade-regulations to bring into harmony many of its unwritten laws, some of the difficulties which now often arise would never occur. At present the Publishers' Association mostly consider

questions outside their own business workings, and nothing in the shape of terms or personal arrangements is touched upon or discussed; therefore unnecessary competition and varying terms exist to a considerable extent. How much unpleasant feeling might be avoided if some broad but definite rules were laid down for the guidance of publishers towards each other, and also to the wholesale and retail bookselling trades. This question will be further discussed later on. A very important question is, however, now awaiting solution—that of sending out books on sale or return. Continental booksellers adopted this method of bringing books before the public many years ago, with a great amount of success and satisfaction, but of course this is a very debatable question.

It appears somewhat difficult for publishers to realize how much could often be done by a bookseller in pushing the sale of a book if he were guaranteed against loss: especially is this applicable to a book by a new author. How much better it would be for author, publisher, and bookseller, if in certain cases books, such as before mentioned, could be shown in windows of retail booksellers, and that the publisher should take them back or exchange them within, say, six months from publication, if still unsold. By these means books by unknown authors would get an advertisement such as could be obtained in no other way, and it would certainly help the bookseller with a show of books which at present he is unable to obtain.

It is somewhat strange that so little difficulty regarding cost or selling price has yet arisen with the issue of the modern cheap editions of books. These cheap issues are published at net prices, they yield a fair profit to those through whose hands they pass, and the public are quite satisfied. Recent history of popular literature shows that success is obtained, not by high prices, but by big sales. What is wanted is the realization of what Matthew Arnold once wrote, "that he hoped for the day when food and books shall both alike be felt as needs."

In connexion with the trade of publishing, the question is, how best to help the bookseller to obtain his supply of books, as the miscellaneous character of the books published, and the increasing number of publishers, and the cost of "travelling" books in the country, make it imperative that some distributing medium should be engaged in this

work. In most countries such an agency exists, but methods vary in each country; it is represented here by the wholesale agent, who supplies from his own stock or collects from the publishers everything a country bookseller may have ordered. By some publishers this agency has a poor recognition, but without such distributing houses it would be quite impossible for the ordinary retail bookseller to obtain his supplies, as the public when ordering books scarcely ever give the publisher's name, and frequently give half a mutilated title, which only those in daily intercourse with all published books could recognize, so that this part of a general system of distribution should not only be fully recognized by the publisher, but in calculating discounts and expenses this distributing method should be considered. One is inclined to ask if there is anything wrong with the trade; if so, is it with the retail bookseller, for after all it is this agency which comes in direct contact with the public. Until the introduction of the net system before mentioned, there was a war of discounts existing which would have eventually meant ruin, and it is only a reasonable conclusion that what every bookseller recognizes as a good to the trade should be further extended. Is not the time ripe for more organization, without oppression, to be adopted by the trade? We have now the organizations of both the publisher and bookseller, to which all the leading members of each of these branches of the trade belong. Why cannot, as before suggested, some rules of a broad but inclusive character be laid down and agreed upon by members of both associations, so that the differences and difficulties which so frequently arise may be easily adjusted? By these means a dignity and influence as of old would be restored to the booksellers, petty grievances would be easily removed, and the question of a living discount would be more easily discussed, and the book world (which formerly had only two interests, that of author and publisher, but now has the bookseller as a separate factor) would be placed on a firmer foundation and in the position which, by its literary association, it deserves.

In recommending closer co-operation between the Publishers' and Booksellers' Associations in the internal arrangements of the bookselling trade, my object is to advocate centralization, but with a liberty which should not be abused. How often a publisher wishes to bring before the various distributing agencies of the trade some work

in which he has invested intelligence and money, and which is not a machine-made book! If such co-operation can be freed from jealousies, what better medium could be found for disseminating information than a central association formed of the above-named organizations? At first there would be much give and take, but if there could be a sub-committee of each association formed which would meet and discuss questions to be submitted to the respective central councils, matters would soon run smoothly, and if the respective presidents or secretaries could be so in touch with each other that preliminary difficulties could be made plain, there is little doubt that results satisfactory to the trade would follow. That important results would follow is practically certain. Take, for instance, the present arrangements for the Annual Meetings of the Publishers' and of the Associated Booksellers. The only attraction of the former is the chairman's address, which, although often eloquent, seldom leads to either a discussion or suggestions, with a result that everything is cut and dried in the most orthodox and dry-as-dust fashion.

Almost the only difference in the Booksellers' Annual Meeting is that it brings members together from all parts of the country and helps to promote social intercourse. Festive gatherings and outings are a greater attraction than the business agenda, and the business man must often have forced upon him the fact that time which is frequently taken up in dinners and receptions could be better spent in discussing business questions. It can scarcely be denied that the two trade associations are capable of far greater usefulness than they at present achieve.

In looking through a recent number of the "Publishers' Weekly," I was much struck by the practical way in which the annual meetings of the book trade of America were conducted. From the report of their proceedings I find that some twelve different subjects associated with the bookselling trade were discussed, among them being the following: Undue Competition of Jobbers; Postage Extra; Self-addressed Circulars issued by Publishers in their interest rather than the Dealers; Discounts to Lending Libraries; Uniform Discounts according to quantity purchased for every dealer alike; Failure to include Juvenile books in the net class.

Surely there could be found a sufficient number of members of the bookselling trade to discuss some of the above or other subjects to the advantage of the trade generally?

When one reflects that the yearly output of English books is considerably less than that of America, which is about one-third that of Germany, and that one-fifth of the inhabited world is dominated by the English language, it is surely time for all the members of the bookselling trade to wake up.

It is not my intention to go into the details of cost prices, but all are agreed that to make an effectual organization for the book trade, the question of profits and terms must come in, both for the publisher as well as for the wholesale and retail bookseller. There is, however, a question which has often been much discussed as to whether trade terms should be based on a flat price, or the system of odd copy and discounts be continued. There is much to be said for both systems, but the method of a sliding scale is invariably used both here and in other countries. In America and Germany, as well as in this country, sometimes the odd copy is given, and even in those countries which charge flat rates there is always an advantage in prices which correspond with numbers. This is only a reasonable concession to those who will speculate, or have built up a business in which a considerable amount of capital is locked up. There are few businesses where speculation is more precarious or where the articles of commerce so quickly deteriorate in value as that of the bookseller, and it is hoped that publishers will soon recognize that bookselling as a trade wants more help and more consideration than it receives at present. Otherwise, the small man will be pushed out, and the trade become centralized in a few big establishments, who will be able to dictate terms for distributing the books published, and a trade union of distributors may be formed which will prove a harder taskmaster than the most tyrannical trade union that has ever dictated terms to its employers. Every one, however, in the trade sincerely hopes that when the publisher and bookseller are brought more in contact with each other through their associations, these important points will be mutually considered from a practical point of view.

It is often wise to see how the business of bookselling is carried on in other countries, so a glance at some of their methods should be interesting.

In Germany, before the war, nearly all booksellers had an agent in Leipzig. This agent receives his client's order every day, and after dispatching them to different publishers, he collects the parcels and sends them off by post or rail. A "collector," as we know him in London, is not known there.

Most firms give credit, and customers go into Leipzig once every year to the "Booksellers' House," when they pay their agent and the publishers.

Firms in Berlin have a special way of dispatching their books, etc., to other firms in the country. It is a kind of private post service between the Booksellers' League in Berlin and booksellers and wholesale agents in other towns. Each member of this League pays a certain amount yearly, and has his goods sent on by the private post service. This is not a very quick method, although it is cheap.

The following Consular Report upon this subject will be found interesting:—

Even in this changing age the organization of the German book trade remains in principle what it has long been. The two main principles which make the trade as flourishing as it is, are the fixed selling price and the right of the retailer to return unsold books. The first, combined with very long credits, is the solid basis of the existence of the small retail houses, and has favoured the establishment of retailers everywhere. There is in Germany one bookseller for every 5,000 inhabitants, and the consequence of retail shops being found everywhere is that the German publisher spends very little in advertising, for he sends out all his novelties on sale according to a system established with the retail trade, or special wishes of the retailers, which he learns by means of his inexpensive circulars. In no other trade is there so close an understanding cultivated as between the German bookseller and his educated customers. The retailer circulates all his new books

amongst likely buyers, and they become better known than through advertisements. The retailer pays for all the books bought during the year at the Easter Fair of the following year. The discounts vary according to the class of book, from 25 per cent. on the selling price of scientific books to 40 and even 50 per cent. on juvenile literature, besides which eleven copies are sent for ten, or thirteen for a dozen. The enormous number of scientific books published in Germany, including pamphlets, can only be explained by the existence of the intelligent retailers all over the country. The legal organization of the trade is the Verein in Leipzig, consisting of 2,685 members, which lays down regulations for the members of the trade amongst themselves, and for them in their dealings with the public. Thus the maintenance of the selling price (5 per cent. being allowed for cash, periodicals excepted) is rigidly insisted on, and if the rule is broken, it is adjudged by the Verein that publishers shall not supply the offender, or that they shall give him no credit or discount. Connected with this institution is a sort of publishers' and booksellers' clearing house in Leipzig, by which the ordering by retailers and the keeping of accounts between them and the publishers are facilitated and simplified, and the processes of ordering, packing, dispatching, and paying are greatly cheapened. It appears designed to prevent a great variety of petty expenditure, and to it, coupled with the fixed selling price and the long credit, is attributed the success of the trade in Germany.

Again, there is that industrious little country, Norway, which has been termed "A Bookseller's Paradise." But it must be remembered that in that country wealth is more evenly distributed than it is here. There are no paupers, and public schools are plentiful. The English, French, and German languages are taught in most schools, and the Norwegian bookseller is usually a well-educated man and a product of one of the public schools.

The following facts are from a summary of an able address given by Mr. W.H. Arnold before the American Booksellers' Association, and are well worthy of the study of the publishers and the booksellers in this country:—

Bookselling in Norway is so organized as to eliminate almost all the risks to which English booksellers are exposed, to secure satisfactory results for the publishers, and to provide a fair reward for the author. Three trade organizations are in existence—The Publishers' Association, the National Association of Booksellers, and the Provincial Association of Booksellers, the qualification for membership in both the first and the last named being membership of the National Association. All booksellers must be members of the National Association. The Provincial Association includes all booksellers except those in Christiania. There is a National Board of Directors, composed of members of each association.

An applicant wishing to become a bookseller addresses the National Board. A young man of eighteen may become a bookseller when he is thirty; he has twelve years' training—four years as apprentice, eight years as assistant. Besides a knowledge of books, he must give security, and if he can prove he has sufficient funds in hand, the National Directors will give their permission for his beginning business on his own account; but the Directors have it in their power to decide whether a new bookshop is wanted in the district mentioned.

A town of 8,000 people would afford scope for two bookshops. Molde, familiar to English tourists, with a population of 2,200 has one thriving bookseller; Aalesund, with a population of 14,000, has three bookshops, and none of these booksellers need fear the incursion of other rivals.

The subscription to the National Association is 10 krone—about 12s.—per annum; and for the Association's weekly journal, 6s. per annum is charged. An annual list of publications is issued, and once in ten years a reference catalogue is issued, costing about 20s. All miscellaneous publications are issued in paper covers, and can be obtained in cloth, but the paper is the more popular format. The book buyer who decides that the paper volume is worth preserving, if so minded gets it bound in cloth or half leather, cloth costing 1s. 6d. and leather 2s. 6d. Retail prices are always net—there are no price cutters in Norway.

Publishers do not require to call on the trade: a descriptive circular is all that is necessary. The bookseller, after reading this, settles how many copies to buy outright, and additional copies can be had, subject to return. Prices of fiction range from 2s. 6d. to 4s. No reduction in the price of a book is allowed until five years after publication.

Payment for bought books is usually made half yearly, in January and July, and "on sale" volumes are accounted for in January, the volumes sold being paid for in March. The usual trade discount is 25 per cent., and when ten copies are bought an extra copy is included. School-books are always bought outright.

The Provincial Association has a central depot in Christiania, the stock of which company is owned by the Association members. The central depot "collects," packs, and dispatches to its members in the provinces, charging a scheduled rate for this service. Subscription books are all sold through the book stores, the only books disposed of outside recognized channels being religious publications handled by pedlars.

Of course, there can be objections raised to many points in this organization, but what I wish to point out is, that if an association can be of great value to the trade in a small community such as Norway, which experience shows it to be, surely by organizing and blending the different associations in our trade here, similar results may follow. Anyway, it can be safely relied upon that something definite and more workable should take the place of our present half-hearted and semi-distinct organizations which are supposed to supervise the workings of the book trade in this country.

There are other questions one might consider. That of the cheap reprint is often a debatable one, some maintaining that it interferes with the sales of the more expensive editions; others that it often creates interest in a particular book, and, through its issue, inquiries are made for the author's previous books. From some points of view both these arguments have in them an element of truth, but it all depends upon the character of the book.

As a rule the life of works of fiction is very short, except in special cases. The life of works of an author of, say, two or three books, would probably be about three to six months, so for books in this class a limit of twelve months should be allowed before a cheap edition is issued, and according to the popularity of the author, these times should vary up to two or three years before cheap editions of books by authors of long standing are issued, and also the better edition should be cleared from the bookseller's shelves before the cheaper edition is published. From a bookseller's point of view, there is no language too strong in condemnation of the system now much in vogue, that a 2s. edition of a 6s. novel may be issued, and both editions kept in circulation at the same time. Editions selling at various prices are often sold by the author to different publishers, and each price is supposed to appeal to a different public. Can a bookseller be expected to keep a stock of all these editions? If so, his stock of cheap reprints would demand a special warehouse.

The most reasonable course to pursue in all cheap issues is first to see if there is a public to which a cheap edition would appeal, settle a moderate price at which it should be published, allowing a fair profit to the trade, and after a sufficient time has been given for the original edition to have a good run, there may be issued the cheap edition, which, while appealing to a fresh public, will be remunerative to the author and publisher, and, let us hope, a help to civilization and the betterment of mankind.

Much the same argument applies to the speculative religious work. There would not, of course, be so many different editions, but if the book in its special issue is of a distinctly argumentative character, and appeals to a thoughtful and intelligent public, a cheap edition is desirable, not only because it will sell, but because it will make people think, and truth is generally brought to the surface and put into operation by a public who thinks.

I am, therefore, convinced that when due time and consideration have been given to a book, a cheap edition is often not only advisable, but necessary.

Another question is, "Should a book be remaindered, and if so, under what conditions?" This is a very important one, and I am convinced that no definite rule can be laid down which would be applicable to all classes of remainders. There are books remaindered which will sell quickly when brought to the notice of a particular class of readers, and others which are only fit for the hawker's barrow or to be pulped as waste. I have known many books which have been remaindered and have thus had attention drawn to them; occasionally they have been quickly bought up, and often resold at their full published price. To instance only one, the first edition of Fitzgerald's "Omar Khayyám" was sold from a fourpenny box, and copies of this edition afterwards fetched £25. By this means a reputation was established and a position for this book secured. I maintain that discretion should be shown in this as well as in other departments of our trade. There are books which are only fit to become fuel for the fire, while others, either through over-printing or want of pushful advertising, have reached a very limited public, and through the book being reduced in price it has reached an eager public delighted to get a book of such value at a price suited to their limited means. Although bookselling is a business, and a most interesting one, yet it does not exist only for those who carry it on. If there were no bookseller's shops some means would have to be found for disseminating that which goes to making the intelligence of a nation. "Show me the literature of a nation, and I will tell you the character of the people," said a great man, and I am quite convinced that if limits were placed upon the distribution of our books for the benefit of author or bookseller, the Government or the people would soon find some means by which their intellectual wants were supplied.

My firm conviction is that no book should be destroyed which appeals to the intellect or which goes to the formation of character. When the time comes in the life of a book that it has exhausted the sphere for which it was intended, let it be offered as a remainder, and I am sure that it will percolate through the various strata of society until it finds its level of usefulness. This may be in the library of the collector or in the more useful sphere of the homes of the working classes, but a book of any literary value should never be destroyed.

In summarizing the various suggestions made in this paper, I would suggest that the most serious consideration be afforded to the following important propositions, so that more unity and stability may be given to the position of the author, publisher, and the various factors in book-distributing and bookselling.

Firstly, in regard to the author, my contention would be that the first book by an author, however good from a publisher's point of view it may be, should be either sent on sale or made returnable, say within six months. If the book has any literary merit it will be found out by that time, and the copies sent but will be sold. If not, they should be returned, so that the book distributor does not have to share a loss for which the publisher alone is responsible. The author should discourage as much as possible the auction-like action of the literary agent who tries to sell manuscripts to the highest bidder, thus lowering the tone of the relationship between the author and the publisher. And I say with all seriousness that should an author have satisfactory arrangements with a publisher he should stick to him, as I am sure it is best for both parties that a publisher should be able to put all the works of an author in his lists, and not only those issued by himself. By this arrangement a publisher will continue to interest himself in all the books by an author, and by advertising them will materially assist in continuous sales.

Secondly, the publisher should discriminate between books in which he is financially interested, and those which he is publishing to please the ambition of a person who wishes to see his or her name in print. He should also fix his terms and stand by them to both the wholesale and retail trader. These are now fairly carried out by some of the older-established publishers, but in some of their cheaper issues they appear to be unable to discriminate between what is a wholesale order and a wholesale trader.

Thirdly, the question of competition and underselling is still of the utmost importance, and I fear will never be settled until there is united action by a joint committee consisting of representatives of both the Publishers' and Booksellers' Associations, and all books are published at a fixed net price. The great objection to this arrangement is mainly the issue of juvenile and school-books. A margin frequently is

demanding, so that a considerable discount can be given to the schoolmasters and mistresses or the governing bodies of our various educational authorities. It is, however, a fair question to ask, "Why should part of the legitimate profit of the bookseller be taken by the school representatives?" It is to be hoped that by association and unity these unsatisfactory anomalies will be swept away. One of the first subjects these joint associations would have to consider would be the minimum amount of profit which should be given to the retail bookseller. This should be, at least, 25 per cent. off the net selling price, and a further discount to *bona fide* wholesale and export booksellers. If all books were made net, and some such discounts as those mentioned were given, much of the present discontent would be removed, and, with a living profit assured, there would be a great inducement for many of the smaller men in the country to interest themselves in the trade, and thus bring about a renewal of an industry which should be beneficial both to the industrious bookseller as well as the intellectual community.

CHAPTER VII

Term and Sale Catalogues

IN the early seventies, while living at Holloway, it was my good fortune to meet Mr. Edward Arber, who also dwelt in that district. At that time he was making the transcript of the Registers at Stationers' Hall, and also publishing many reprints from Old English literature. It is to the many interesting conversations which I had with him while walking to Stationers' Hall Court, as we both at that time did, that I became more interested in some of the ways of the booksellers of previous generations, and in the introduction and use of the Booksellers' Catalogues. From the origin of printing in England in 1472 until 1526, it is quite a question whether any books which can be considered English literature were produced and printed in this country. The books sold here were mostly foreign productions, and, as numbers of them had an ultra-Romish tendency, it was a sure passport to a cruel death to possess a copy of many of the books of the period. Even these were produced in small octavo size, so that they could be carried in the owner's pocket without discovery.

The earliest register of books published was that by the Company of Stationers of London which began in 1554. This record was carried on until 1640, and it is from these catalogues, of which my friend Mr. Arber devoted the best part of twenty years in producing a transcript, in five folio volumes, that any bibliographer can now trace the authors and date of publication of much of the literature of that period. Following on from the before-mentioned period, there were various classified catalogues issued by different publishers, but in 1662-3 there was published a catalogue of books registered at Stationers' Hall from the 25th of December 1662 to the 25th of December 1663. This was the first attempt at the yearly issue of a complete list of books published, and, it is supposed, was brought to an end by the Plague and the Great Fire of London, which we know from "Pepys's Diary" and other records caused the destruction of an immense number of books to the value of some £200,000.

The next important series of Catalogues were "The Term Catalogues of Books printed in England." These were begun in November 1668 and ended in June 1709. Their title was evidently taken from a legal point of view, as they were divided into periods of Michaelmas Term, Hilary Term, Easter Term and the Trinity Term. The catalogues were very carefully reproduced in three volumes by Mr. Arber, and often gives me much material for speculative thought and reflection. In an introductory preface to these Term Catalogues, Mr. Arber writes: "There is something perfectly God-like in a wide survey for a given period of the entire literature of a great nation. It is like Moses viewing from Mount Pisgah the whole of the land of promise, and will help us to a better understanding of and a greater delight in the ages of the Restoration of William and Mary and of Queen Anne." These catalogues were intended to be an annual list of the books entered at Stationers' Hall, and no London stationer could lawfully publish a book until he had been made free of this Company.

In looking through the volumes of catalogues above referred to, I have been greatly interested in the titles of some of these old books. What food for thought must there have been in some of the following: "Sober Singularity, or an Antidote against Infection by the example of a Multitude"; "The Arts of Grandeur and Submission, a discourse concerning the behaviour of great men towards their inferiors"; "A Mirror or a Looking-glass for Saints and Sinners"; "The Ladies Blush"; "The Citizen turn'd Gentleman"; "Two Bulls

roaring out Excommunication" (the first by Pope Paul III against Henry VIII; the other by Pope Pius V against Queen Elizabeth); "The Worth of a Penny; with the causes of the scarcity and the misery of the want thereof, in these hard and mercyleless times"; "A Mirror that Flattereth not"; "A new Map of the Seat of the War in Germany so designed that you may presently know whether name of any place be in the map or not, and to see by inspection the distance of it from any other place without measuring by compasses"; "A Catholic Pill to purge Popery"; "England's Glory, or the great improvement of trade in general by a Royal Bank or Office of Credit to be erected in London, that they may give out bills of credit to a vast extent that all Europe will accept of rather than money." By the title it is evident that the finances of this country were as important to the world then as they are to-day.

This list could be increased to fill a volume of these quaint and interesting titles. It also contained a list of the publications of many books, which are popular to-day by great authors such as John Bunyan, R. Baxter, Milton, Shakespeare, and others. One could not help noticing the names of some publishers which are well known in the book trade to-day, such as A. & J. Churchill, Collins, J. Moxon, Richard Bentley, although of course they are not the successors to those of the Term Catalogue period. The Catalogue also states that in 1702 the "Daily Courant" was started, being the first daily newspaper to be published in London. I find also in these volumes what I think is the first notice of the odd copy being given. The advertisement runs as follows: "Proposals are now published for printing all the practical works of the late Rev. Mr. Robert Baxter in four volumes and in folio, many of which he wrote at the desire of Archbishop Ussher. To contain one thousand sheets of a large and very good paper, the price to subscribers four pounds, ten shillings in quires, the seventh book gratis, which reduces it to £3 12s. 2d. The proposals at large may be had of the Undertakers, Thomas Parkinson and others." Ever since this period, the giving of the odd copy has been frequently discussed, but it appears quite possible that by the introduction of the net system it has received a very serious stoppage which may lead to its final abolition.

The earliest book auction sale recorded took place at Warwick Court, Warwick Lane, in 1676, and in the following ten years only seventy-three auction sales of books are recorded as having been held. These auctions

usually began at nine in the morning, and biddings might advance at a penny per time. The sales, however, differed from the sales of a later period. Formerly at the sales I attended the lots of books fell to the highest bidder, but although an auctioneer was usually present, he could only sell by a scale according to numbers, which was arranged by the publisher for whom the auctioneer acted. These delightful old catalogues are a continual source of inspiration to all booksellers, even if it is only the author or title of a book in which he is interested.

It is, however, the sale catalogues of the eighteenth and the greater part of the nineteenth century which interest me most. It was a period which may be called the Golden Age of bookselling. The sale catalogues of this later time unfortunately came to an end in 1890, with that of Richard Bentley & Son, whose business was afterwards taken over by Messrs. Macmillan & Co. At the end of this catalogue, dated October 21, 1890, there was reprinted from "The Bookseller" an article on "Trade Sale Dinners," to which I contributed some of the information, and I am indebted to the courteous head of Messrs. Whitaker & Co. for allowing me to reproduce it in this chapter. It is as follows:

"The very ancient institution, peculiar to booksellers, of dining together on the occasion of a trade sale, is almost extinct and is, we very much regret to think, likely to become entirely so in the near future.

"The fashion of dining together on the occasion of a sale is a very old one. An interesting collection of sale catalogues in the possession of Mr. William Reader contains specimens dating back to 1704. They consist of the catalogues sent in the ordinary course of business to Osborne and his successor, the first of the Longmans. It is evident from these catalogues that sale dinners were a well-established custom of the trade as long ago as the beginning of the eighteenth century; and, as it must have required considerable time for the practice to have developed into a custom, their first beginnings may possibly have been as far back as 'the spacious times of great Elizabeth,' when bookselling first took shape as a regular trade.

"The first catalogue in Mr. Reader's collection is that of the stock of Mrs. Elizabeth Harris, deceased, which is to be sold at 'The Bear, in

Avey Mary Lane,' on the 11th December, 1704, 'beginning at 9 in the morning, when the whole company shall be entertained with a breakfast, and at noon with a good dinner and a glass of wine, and then proceed with the sale in order to finish that evening.' The sale of the stock of the late John Nicholson took place in 1718 at the Queen's Head Tavern in Paternoster Row, and the catalogue bears marginal notes in Osborne's handwriting, the names of Curil and Tonson appearing amongst the buyers. Nicholson's interest in certain share books was also disposed of, including Robert Clavel's shares, which he had formerly acquired. (Robert Clavel was a bookseller who flourished during the latter half of the previous century. He carried on business at the Peacock, in St. Paul's Churchyard, and in 1673 issued the well-known 'Catalogue of all the Books Printed in England since the Dreadful Fire of London in 1666 to the end of Michaelmas Term, 1672.') Nicholson's stock and shares appeared to have realized altogether £2,533, a very respectable sum for those days.

"It is remarkable that these sale catalogues were printed in almost exactly the same form as those of our own day. Nearly all are in folio, with broad margins for annotations, and they are addressed to 'A select number of Booksellers of London and Westminster,' in the identical terms still current. Only those who were invited by having a catalogue sent them were expected to attend the sale, and the invitations were restricted to booksellers of established position. 'No stallmen admitted' is the significant notice printed at the head of one of the catalogues.

"It was not always a dinner that was given; sometimes it was a supper at which the buyers were entertained, as at the sale of Edward Valentine's stock in 1725, on the margin of which catalogue we first meet with the name of Longman among the buyers. In any case, however, whether the stock sold was that of an individual bookseller or a miscellaneous assortment from several contributors, it was the invariable custom to entertain those who came with a substantial repast 'and a glass of good wine.' At Thomas Osborne's sale in 1743, the catalogue even recites the delicacies which were provided, 'consisting of turkies and chines, hams and chickens, apple-pies, etc., and a glass of very good wine.'

"Thirteen years later, in 1756, the sale took place of part of the stock of the late Thomas Longman, Osborne's successor and founder of the great Paternoster Row house. The copyrights and shares of Jacob and Richard Tonson were sold in August, 1767, and we notice the names of Dilly, Rivington, and Newbery amongst the buyers. Many of the copyrights were offered in twentieths, for the convenience of bidders. At that time, and long afterward, the risk and expense of publishing a book were jointly borne by a group of booksellers, who met periodically to agree upon the number to be printed, and to audit accounts, and these shares constantly appear in the sale catalogues of the period.

"The trade sales were always held at some selected tavern or coffee-house; until 1754, they took place at the Queen's Head Tavern in Paternoster Row, and up to that time it is a rare exception to find them held elsewhere. But in 1755 they were removed to the Queen's Arms in St. Paul's Churchyard, in consequence, as a note on a catalogue of that date states, of the Queen's Head Tavern being converted to another use. For many years subsequently the Queen's Arms continued in favour, and sales were held there as late as 1813; but from about 1790 the London Coffee House on Ludgate Hill seems to have had the preference. The Horn Tavern, Doctors' Commons, was sometimes selected, and less frequently the Globe Tavern, in Fleet Street, where as long ago as 1768, a sale was held. The Chapter Coffee House in Paternoster Row was sometimes used, but not often, although the share-meetings continued to take place there until a very recent date. The London Coffee House gradually obtained a monopoly of the trade sales, until they were finally transferred to the Albion Tavern in Aldersgate Street.

"During a period of nearly a hundred and ninety years the sales appear to have been almost exclusively held at five houses, which, as time went on, succeeded each other in favour. The transfer to the Albion was gradual, but in 1831 the greater number were already held there, and in recent years seldom took place elsewhere, though occasionally one was held as far west as the Freemasons' Tavern in Great Queen Street.

"Within the present generation, the houses having annual sale dinners numbered about fourteen—Bentley, Bickers, Bohn, Chatto & Windus, Longmans, Macmillan, Murray, Quaritch, Routledge, Seeley and Burnside, Tegg, Ward and Lock, Warne, and Whittaker; and of these only two now survive. Messrs. Longmans' last sale dinner took place on November 5, 1872, and Mr. Murray's last dinner on November 4, 1887.

"It is curious that the form of trade sale catalogues should have remained so long unchanged. The old-fashioned yellow-wove post folios of Murray are well remembered. Those of Bentley are somewhat different. Their catalogues were printed in red and black for some years, but since 1885 in blue and brown; and, with a single exception, in 1880, their dinners always took place at the Albion."

It was in connexion with the firm with which I have been for so many years associated, that I happened, quite accidentally, some thirty years ago, to come across a parcel of catalogues which were placed with a heap of papers to be sent to the paper mills for destruction. My interest in them was such that as they were considered only waste paper, I took the bundle home, and they have since been to me an endless source of pleasure and instruction. Some of these catalogues are dated 1797, but from the early part of the nineteenth century, judging from the catalogues, books and booksellers had a very prosperous period. At this time, the following publishers and booksellers had a large number of titles in their catalogues, and in many instances they were very important publications. Among them are Sir Richard Phillips (Lord Mayor of London), Darton & Harvey (10 Crosby Square), Joseph Johnson, J. Walker, F. & C. Rivington, Murray & Highley (the predecessors of the celebrated house of John Murray), Longman, Hurst Rees & Orme (who at this period had a very miscellaneous catalogue of books, including plays), Wilson & Spence of York, Henry Mozley of Gainsborough, Cadell & Davies, J. Stockdale of Piccadilly, Scotcherd & Letterman, W. Miller, C. Law, Constable, Vernor & Hood, G. & J. Robinson, and R. Baldwin. Most of these catalogues contain books which had been issued by a combination of bookseller publishers; the shares in the publication of a particular book were divided up by those interested in the book; and the profits were divided between those who contributed to its publication.

A catalogue, dated April 1805, of Joseph Maurnan, agent to the University of Cambridge, besides enumerating Bibles of various sizes, from folio to twelves and twenty-fours, and Common Prayers of a like character (these were sold 5 for 4, 9 for 7, 12 for 10, and other numbers with a similar reduction), also contained such books as "Lambe on Constitutional Diseases"; Ruddiman's "Rudiments," new edition; Ruffhead's "Statutes," 18 vols., £38; New Geographical Game upon cards in a box, 7s. 6d.; also a collection of Plays and Farces.

Another catalogue, dated June 1805, shows that at this period women held a position amongst the booksellers. This catalogue was issued by Elizabeth Mathews, 18 Strand, and the terms of the sale were four months' credit for £10; four and eight months' for £20; four, eight, and twelve months' for £50; four, eight, twelve, and sixteen for £100: money was evidently not of the same value then as now. Some of the most important books in this catalogue were "Annual Register," 33 vols.; Buffon's "Natural History," 15 vols.; Sheraton's "Cabinet Maker's Drawing Book," 18s.; "Encyclopædia Britannica," 20 vols. Another of the same period also contained many important works such as "Johnson's Dictionary," in 4 vols., Mavor's "Voyages and Travels," 25 vols., Radcliffe's "Mysteries of Udolpho," 4 vols.; "Pinder's Works," 5 vols.; Pope's "Homer," 5 vols. "Shakespeare's Works," in 21 vols., and with four different editions in 10 vols. and two in 9 vols., are all in this catalogue. From this period onward the same characteristics appear in catalogues, but by degrees, when publishers only sold the books they published, the constitution of the catalogue and the sales greatly changed and the business done was more ordinary and commonplace. I have spent many most enjoyable occasions when attending these sales, and also met there many distinguished people connected both with the trade and also with the making of literature.

As a few samples of the characteristics and the business done at some of the sale dinners when the custom was drawing to a close, I may mention that at Murray's sale, in 1885, the completing volume of the "Speaker's Commentary" was among the works offered, and some 2,500 copies were sold within the first ten minutes; of that great traveller Du Chaillu's "Land of the Midnight Sun," in 2 vols., about 1,800 copies were sold. The educational works of Dr. Smith were then in great demand, and there were disposed of at this sale some 7,500 copies of his "English Course," and of

the Latin 16,000, while of "Little Arthur's History of England," 12,500 copies were sold.

At another sale, when Bishop Wilberforce's Life was the leading book offered, the principal sales were as follows: 1,000 Mudie's Library, 900 Simpkin, Marshall & Co., 450 Hamilton & Co., 250 Smith & Son, 100 W. Kent, and 100 Hatchard's, whilst 22,500 of Smith's Latin Course were quickly purchased.

Times and the methods of education have greatly changed, but there are two things respecting these sales which strike me very forcibly. These are the comparatively small sales to-day of the above-mentioned educational works, also whether the publisher has been wise to stop these trade sales. They undoubtedly not only brought publishers and booksellers together, but offered an inducement to the booksellers which does not exist to the same extent to-day to make up stock orders and interest themselves in books.

Personally, as I have suggested in other chapters, I should be delighted to see some organized association brought into existence of which all those interested in the making and selling of books could become members, so that representatives of the different departments of the trade might meet together and talk over or discuss questions connected with it. This I am sure would lead to a greater and more satisfactory prosperity in all departments of the publishers' and booksellers' trade than has ever yet been attained.

CHAPTER VIII

Limited Editions and the Pleasures of Collecting

IT would be quite impossible within the limits of a short chapter to deal with such a great subject as the above title represents. The subject, however, is fascinating not only to the book collector but to those in the trade, both new and second-hand, through whose hands the books pass.

Until the introduction of printing, what may be termed books or literature were all limited editions, as in olden times it was only by the industry of the scribes that other copies could be produced. Privately printed originally

meant printed in a university or private residence and not in the offices of an ordinary printer. Now, however, privately printed and limited editions have each much the same meaning, as they are both practically limited in the numbers printed.

I must confess that I have a profound sympathy with all collectors of this particular class of book-producing, for it is with great pride that one takes down from the shelves a volume of this class of literature and reads how many copies of it were printed, and any history that may be connected with it. This attraction is from my point of view as far apart as the poles from that of collecting works produced before the origin of printing or even those in the centuries afterwards, where frequently the mistakes in printing make the value of the book. Such, for instance, as that of the Bible where the word "not" is left out in one of the commandments, or where a chance misprint or mistake is noted in some of Shakespeare's or other Elizabethan plays. A long list could easily be made of the small things that render some of these ancient volumes valuable.

To-day, these limited editions are produced in the most careful, complete, and perfect manner possible. From a real book-lover's point of view, the beauty of the type, the excellency of the paper and the artistic merit of its binding, coupled with the literary value of the book itself, make a volume which one is proud to possess and have upon one's shelves. For some years past there has been a considerable demand for the limited issue of well-illustrated books numbered and signed by such artists as Rackham, Dulac, and others; these are widely sought after and collected; so also are those works issued by private presses of which the past fifty years has seen some splendid developments. Take, for instance, the Ashenden Press, with its beautiful edition of Dante; the Kelmscott Press, under the guidance of William Morris, which issued many of his own books (the wood-blocks of his works are now in the keeping of the British Museum, with whom they were deposited on the understanding that no one is to be at liberty to print from them for a hundred years); the Vale Press, which limited its editions to 200 copies; the Cardoc Press; the Eragny Press; the Essex House Press; the Dove Press, which finished its course in 1917 by the type being "cast" into the Thames and "distributed" at the bottom of the river; and Mr. Daniel's Press at Oxford. Although these various presses appeal to the collector, first editions and rare books have a greater number of collectors, whose lives are

frequently passed in hunting after and trying to discover and secure lost old volumes.

This pleasurable following to-day has not the advantages that existed in the middle of the past century, as not only are there now more seekers after these treasures of the past, but America has so many collectors of old books that the demand is greater and the prices higher. These drawbacks will greatly interfere with both the business and the enjoyment of future collectors. The chances, too, of the old-book collector are not nearly so great as formerly, for the changes which have taken place, particularly in London, have certainly swept away many of their favourite haunts. It is to many a very great pleasure to look back in memory upon old Holywell Street, with its scores of book-hunters turning over the boxes and seeking for treasures. Mr. W.E. Gladstone and many dignitaries of the Church could often be seen there. Fleet Street, the Strand, Holborn, and many of the by-streets between Oxford Street and Trafalgar Square, were great thoroughfares for the book-hunter; and although the barrows of Farringdon Street are still in existence, either the bookstall man now knows his business better than his predecessor or the gems are sold before he places these precious books on his barrow. Many times I have turned over the stock of old books on these Farringdon Street barrows, but have never yet been able to find anything of value, although others have been more fortunate. We have now no such opportunities as those of Charles Lamb; and I cannot say if we would avail ourselves of them even if we had. Lamb writes (March 25, 1829):—

"I have just come from town where I have been to get my bit of quarterly pension. I have brought home from stalls in Barbican the old 'Pilgrims Progress' with the prints Vanity Fair, etc., now scarce, four shillings, cheap. And also one of whom I have oft heard and had dreams, but never saw it in the flesh—that is in sheep-skin—"The whole Theological works of Thomas Aquinas.' My arms ached with lugging it a mile to the stage, but the burden was a pleasure."

All lovers of books must at some time feel the fascination of the second-hand bookseller's shop, and especially when it has a "Tuppenny Box" attached to it. At such shops, you may examine every book in the place, read a little, look at the pictures and the binding, have a gossip with the

intelligent bookseller, and never be asked to spend a penny. The keeper of such books usually knows his business and the origin and history of much of his stock, and is able to tell some good bookish stories in keeping with his profession. A true lover of books thinks little of their monetary value but treasures a volume because of its contents, or perhaps for some association or memory connected with the author.

One cannot get away from the feeling, when surrounded by old books, that there is probably some unsuspected treasure hidden among the volumes handled with so much pleasure. What a thrill would pass through you if you discovered one of Shakespeare's original plays or some other of the many precious dramas of the Elizabethan age. Or a first edition of Scott, Lamb, Burns, Blake, or even one of Dr. Watts' Divine Songs containing "Let dogs delight to bark and bite," a copy of which was sold for £155. It is said that the bibliomaniac fever generally begins at the bookstall. Of all kinds of human weakness, the craze for buying and collecting old books is the most excusable. In the early phases of this complaint, the book-lover is content to purchase only books which he reads; next, he buys books which he means to read, and, as his stores accumulate, hopes to read; by and by he takes home books in beautiful bindings, or artistic illustrations, or of an early date, and sometimes printed in a language which he cannot read. Once a lover, always a lover, is a true saying, particularly when applied to a lover of books. As old age draws near, the lover of books finds a solace and joy in the companionship of his silent friends, which not only increases as the years pass on but undoubtedly helps to maintain his interest in life. He may retire from active business at any time, and still in his retirement be as happy and contented as at any period of his more strenuous days.

In my own case many of these ideals have been realized. Numberless volumes have been written on the pleasures of book-hunting and its results. Some glory in their collection of books upon certain subjects, such as Angling and all other kinds of sport; some have libraries on Philosophy, History, Biography, Architecture, and other branches of intellectual study; others collect fiction and first editions of celebrated authors, many of which have only a fleeting value. In whatever way we regard book-collecting, there can be no doubt that if carried through from an intellectual point of view, there are few things in life which are so rich in quiet satisfaction or which give such gratifying results to both mind and body.

It has been well said by Mr. J.A. Langford in his interesting volume entitled "The Praise of Books": "A wise man will select his books, for he would not wish to class them all under the sacred name of friends. Some can be accepted only as acquaintances. The best books of all kinds are taken to the heart and cherished as his most precious possession. Others to be chatted with for a time, to spend a few pleasant hours with, and laid aside, but not forgotten."

Such are some of the pleasures and the profits to be derived from collecting, be it first editions, scarce books, or limited editions.

CHAPTER IX

The Whitefriars Club

OF all the institutions with which I have been associated, not one has given me so much pleasure, or of which I feel so proud in belonging to, as The Whitefriars Club. This Club was founded in 1865, and is a survival of the old Bohemian life of London; it knows no sect or politics, and its ambition is to create true fellowship amongst its members.

The Club has a room and meets at Anderton's Hotel in that highway of letters, Fleet Street. During the autumn and winter months it has always been their custom to hold meetings each Friday to hear an address from some distinguished publicist upon a subject of common interest and importance. After the introductory speech by the guest of the evening, the subject is open to discussion, and each member is invited to express his views and convictions as freely as possible. While listening to these speeches, I have often wished that reporters had been allowed to be present, as I am sure those connected with newspapers would have found these debates of more interest than those taking place in a building of a greater national importance. During the temporary retirement of our present excellent secretary, Mr. W.N. Shansfield, I had the honour and pleasure of acting as the Club's secretary for three years. At the end of my term of office, I was delighted to receive a beautiful pair of candelabra as a present

from the Club, the greatly revered Lord Roberts being the guest of the evening on this occasion. I can safely say that this presentation was one of the most interesting events in my life, as after it had been made, Lord Roberts rose from his seat, came round to me, shook hands, and uttered some pleasant words of congratulation. To me the occasion was a memorable one. There are, however, so many interesting associations connected with this Club that I must go back to 1901, the year of my becoming a member.

At the time of my joining the Hon. Secretary was Sir Arthur Spurgeon, who has always been most loyal and helpful to members of the Club, and to whom every one is deeply indebted for the interest and support he has given to it. He it was who helped to develop the Club and made it one of the great centres of journalistic and literary London. The Club can never have a better or more thorough and efficient officer than the present secretary, my good friend, Mr. W.N. Shansfield. He is always at his post, and by his many amiable qualities greatly stimulates and carries on the friendly intercourse at which the Club aims. Every member of the Club is entitled to the distinction of being a Friar, and the one who presides at our festivities is for the evening the Prior, so that discipline and order among the Brotherhood is a foregone conclusion.

The following toast is always given at each meeting by the Prior and is heartily responded to by the Friars and guests present: "Friars and Guests,—By this wine we commemorate the White Friars of old, fortified with spirit—the spirit of admiration for their services to charity and good learning—and sweetened by sympathy for those who, broken by fortune, dwell in Alsatia. It is left for me, as Prior of the day, to add the cordial—a cordial welcome to the guests of the Brotherhood assembled at our board. Gentlemen, I bid a hearty welcome to you all, and invite you to join with the Brothers of a gracious order in drinking to the prosperity of the Whitefriars Club."

Among the Priors who have presided at our gatherings memory calls up many who were leaders in the world of Literature and Journalism, such as William Senior, Richard Whiteing, G. Manville Fenn, Sir F. Carruthers Gould, Sir J. Foster Fraser, Sir Arthur Spurgeon, Sir Anthony Hope, G.B. Burgin (who also edits "The Whitefriars Journal"), Edward Clodd, Clement K. Shorter, Sir W. Robertson Nicoll and Sir William Treloar, who have all

distinguished themselves by their aptitude and eloquence. It would be a breach of the rules of our Order to give any account of the various nobles and gentlemen who have honoured the Club by their presence. Sufficient to say that, be the invited guest ever so exalted, the Club's invitation is seldom declined. Many times I have heard from a guest what a delightful evening he has spent and the enjoyment he has experienced in the good fellowship which dominates the members and the proceedings of the Club.

On two occasions during the year, we have what is termed "Ladies' Nights." This may appear strange to those who think that the monastic order is carried out in its entirety, but I am sure the evening is always as enjoyable to the ladies as it is to the Friars. On these occasions, we have the toast of "Mere Man," proposed by a lady, and, as a set off, the toast of "Sov'ram Woman," of course proposed by a Friar; and each is equally appreciated. A volume which would be of great interest to the public generally, might easily be compiled of extracts from the Journals of the Club, but as it is understood by the members that no reporters are present at our meetings, and that the proceedings are for the members only and that no publicity is given to them, I must not depart from this order of secrecy.

One of my early associations with the Club was on the visit of Mark Twain to this country. He was invited to accompany some of the members to Lambeth Palace, to hear an address from the Librarian upon the many beautiful MSS. which the Library contained. This was most interesting, as was also the visit to the Lollards' Tower, with its many religious associations. After our visit to the Palace we were invited to take tea, if I remember rightly, at the Authors' Club. Here a number of notable authors and others were assembled to welcome the American guest, among them being Dr. Stubbs, Bishop of Oxford, and Canon Barnett. I was one of a group who were narrating some of their interesting experiences, when the Rev. Canon told a story which greatly amused his hearers and especially the members of our Club. The story caused shouts of laughter and the Bishop held up his hands in apparent surprise, and made some remark respecting it. I happened to suggest that the rev. gentleman should be called to order by the Bishop, but he again held up his hands and said, "Not in my Diocese," a retort which caused more laughter than the story.

There is one association in connexion with the Whitefriars Club which I shall not be breaking their rules by mentioning. This is our "Summer

Outing" in June or July, to which ladies were always invited. One of these "Outings"—and certainly to me the one in which I found my greatest anticipations realized—was that made to the home of our great novelist, George Meredith, in 1902. I give, therefore, the following sketch from notes made by myself and a small extract from the Club's Journal.

It was on a cloudy, windy, but exhilarating day that a company of "Whitefriars" started on a pilgrimage to Burford Bridge and Box Hill to visit one of England's greatest novelists, George Meredith. The railway journey proved far too short, as we spent the time in discussing with some of our gifted fellow-travellers questions social and political, one topic being "Would England become peopled by an effeminate race should it cease to foster a jingo or warlike spirit." Needless to say, no final discussion upon this stupendous subject was reached before arriving at our destination. At Burford Bridge a capital lunch had been provided, after which the Prior for the day, Mr. Robert Leighton, proposed the health of Friar George Meredith. Other toasts were proposed or responded to by Madam Sarah Grand, Mr. T.P. O'Connor, M.P., and Friar Sir Arthur Spurgeon.

After luncheon, a short walk over one of Surrey's most beautiful hills brought us to the haven of our desires. Here, nestled under the shade of hill and foliage, stood Flint Cottage, the charming but unpretentious residence of Friar George Meredith.

Above the house stands the Châlet, the workshop of the great novelist, eloquent in its stillness and solitude. In this Châlet many of his masterpieces have been written.

Every one at some period in their lives has probably experienced that extreme tension of feelings when they are about to realize that which a vivid imagination has created and built up until it has become a veritable brain picture.

We entered the grounds surrounding Flint Cottage, passing in single file along the paths of a well-kept garden to a rustic seat in a small meadow-like enclosure where the great novelist sat. With a hearty shake of the hand as each visitor was introduced and a cheery word of greeting to many an old friend, we passed before our host, then stood about in groups or sat buoyantly expectant of what was to follow.

While waiting for the sound of a voice that will never be forgotten, time was given to reflect upon our first impression of the man whose name is honoured wherever English literature is known or read. To the mind which admires all that is great in the world of reality or imagination, it almost savours of sacrilege to attempt to describe or analyse that which one looks up to and venerates. It is therefore with the greatest humility that reference is here made to that lofty embodied intelligence which until then had been known only through the medium of George Meredith's writings.

Judging from appearances, the world-renowned novelist was quite an ordinary-looking man of between sixty and seventy years of age. He was dressed in a dark blue holiday suit, with a red tie, and held a grey wideawake hat in his hand. His white but luxuriant hair partly covered a high and noble forehead, which indexed a striking and characteristic personality. All these details, however, were the outside man. It was when he began to talk that our attention became riveted, for in the deep resonant flexibility of his voice one became almost electrified. Its penetration, as it conveyed the measured periods of the speaker, immediately attracted attention, and a hush of expectancy stole over the listening company. Early in the proceedings, Prior Robert Leighton read the following address:

"Friar George Meredith,—We, members of the Whitefriars Club and our friends, are gratefully conscious of the honour you accord to us in permitting us a second time to call upon you here at your home. Be assured we come to you to-day not with any feeling approaching vulgar curiosity to invade and peep within the sanctities of your chosen seclusion. We come with the reverence of pilgrims journeying to a hallowed shrine; content if you do but allow us to enter at your gates to offer you our respectful homage, to take your hand and listen for some moments to the living voice of one to whom we individually and the world in general owe so much.

"The work that you have done has become a part of English life and of our own personal lives. It represents the highest blossom of the tree of civilization, and it has come to mean so much that to-day no man or woman can attain to a maturity of culture without having absorbed your teaching and your spirit. You have taught us to appreciate everything that is good in life, enhancing its sparkle and flavour. You have sharpened our wits, polished our manners, advanced our happiness by widening our comprehension. You have given us a new perception of the social structure, and especially have you given us a key to the maze and mystery of women's souls.

"You yourself, sir, in your splendid solitude, can hardly apprehend what the name of George Meredith means to the best intelligences of your era. It is a name honoured and venerated above all titles, signifying to us, your disciples, the sum of all your imaginative genius and your noble example have conferred. We, men and women alike, who are privileged to see you to-day, are sensible of the added understanding which comes of personal association with you, and we shall remember the privilege as one of the most cherished benefits of our lives."

Friar George Meredith said: "I cannot rise, but I wish to speak and say: Ladies and Gentlemen, after a shower of honey from the busiest bees of the bees around me, my wings are clogged, and I cannot fly. I have no words to thank you. But look at the tops of those trees: from that short height the measure of us is seen to be pretty equal. Each does his work in his own way. I find so many people in different walks that can do what I cannot do. Respect is a very great thing, but I think we are in the habit of falling into a kind of delirium in regard to men who after seventy years or more have made a name. We take them as brandy—(laughter)—it is better to make a kind of dilution, and therefore I mix a considerable amount of water with your compliments. (Laughter.) However, I thank you heartily for coming to see me. If I had the eloquence of that true Irishman, Mr. T.P. O'Connor, I should be making an impression now—(laughter)—but I am only half Irish—half Irish and half Welsh—I halt therefore rather on one leg. The Welsh are admirable singers, but bad dancers. Mr. O'Connor would say not only the words most appropriate, but his language would flow on, and you would not be able to stop him. (Laughter.) I have not that gift, I can only thank you for your kindness. (Loud applause.)"

Some of the visitors left their host to visit the Châlet, which, judging from its dusty appearance, now rarely received a visit from its master. This literary workshop consists of two rooms, one for work and the other for rest and refreshment. The former contained a well-selected library of English and foreign books, all exhibiting the appearance of having been well used. Brockhaus's Great Lexicon was a prominent feature in the library, which also contained first editions of several of Meredith's own books and various autograph presentation works from some of his literary friends. On the writing table there were many well-used quill pens and scraps of MS., which to the relic hunter were objects of great temptation, but reverence forbade sacrilege. Through fear of our tiring a body which Nature has made far too weak for such a mind, the pilgrimage had to be brought to an early close, so with minds stimulated and trying to hold some of the wise thoughts and expressions which had fallen from the great novelist's lips, we returned to our hotel.

After the tea provided by our always practical secretary, a few short and thoughtful speeches were delivered by the Prior, Sir William Treloar and the Rev. W.J. Dawson; then, with cordial farewells and those pleasing amenities which help so much in making such outings as these doubly enjoyable, we journeyed back to the station and to town. So ended what to others beside myself will always be remembered as one of the red-letter days of our lives.

Another delightful outing was to Colchester and Constable's country. There, we were not entertained with "Oysters and Erings Roots," but with the historical memorials for which this town and district are famous. After going over the Abbey, the Town Hall, and admiring the four bronze Ravens which are supposed to be relics of the tenth century, we drove through the Constable country, visiting "The Vale of Dedham," passing the Elizabethan Grammar School where John Constable was educated, "Willy Lotts House" and "Flatford Mill." During another summer, our journey was to the Dickens country. After alighting at Sole Street station and visiting the Leather Bottle, with its numerous Dickens relics, and Cobham Church, we drove to Rochester and lunched at the celebrated Bull Hotel, so humorously associated with Mr. Winkle. Later on in the day we visited the Cathedral and Dean Hole's delightful garden of roses.

The House of the Seven Poor Travellers fascinated us greatly, as here we were shown Dickens' signature when he spent the night getting material for his Christmas story of the "Seven Poor Travellers." We also inspected the outbuildings in which he and the other travellers slept. Among other journeys of very great interest, was one by train to Oxford and from thence by boat up the Thames to Goring: the scenery through which we passed is well known for its bewildering beauty.

Most interesting to me, as I happened to be at the time the Hon. Secretary, was our pilgrimage to Hatfield House. Upon arriving at Hatfield House and being received with a kindly shake of the hand by the Countess of Salisbury, she showed us through the rooms in which are located many wonderful historical treasures. More especially to be admired was the collection of arms, many of which had been captured from the Spanish Armada. The great library and the wonderful pictures by Holbein, Van Dyck, Reynolds, and others, fascinated us all, but perhaps the most interesting were the various relics connected with Queen Elizabeth: the oak-

tree under which she was seated when the news came of Queen Mary's death and of her own accession to the throne; the cradle once occupied by Elizabeth; and a pair of her silk stockings, and a garden bonnet which she wore when walking in the surrounding woods.

On leaving Hatfield House we drove over to St. Albans, where we visited the old and delightful Cathedral, rich in its historical associations, and, after an enjoyable dinner at one of the hotels, returned home with minds full of the events which have helped to make the greatness of England.

I might mention other delightful "outings" and events, but those which I have given show the many fascinating episodes associated with the Whitefriars Club.

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